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Corporate giants pledge big money to power India AI infra

MAJOR BETS. RIL-Jio leads with ₹10 lakh-crore commitment; Adani, Amazon, Google, Microsoft and Qualcomm back India’s sovereign AI and data centre expansion

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Leading corporates announced significant investment commitments at the India AI Impact Summit 2026, headlined by Jio and Reliance’s ₹10-lakh crore pledge to be deployed over the next seven years.

“This is not speculative investment. It is not for chasing valuation. This is patient, disciplined, nation-building capital designed to create durable economic value and strategic resilience for decades to come,” Mukesh D Ambani, Chairman and Managing Director, Reliance Industries, said at the Summit on Thursday.

Ambani said the biggest constraint for artificial intelligence (AI) today is not talent or imagination, but scarcity and high cost of compute. Therefore, he said, Jio Intelligence will build India’s sovereign compute infrastructure through three initiatives, including gigawatt-scale data centres.

“We have already started

construction on multi-gigawatt, AI-ready data-centres at Jamnagar. Over 120 MW will come online in the second half of 2026, and a clear path to gigawatt-scale compute for training and largescale inference,” he said.

ADANI’S INVESTMENT
The Adani Group committed \$100 billion to a sovereign, green-energy-powered AI platform, calling it “the trigger for a 5-gigawatt, \$250 billion integrated energy-and-compute ecosystem engineered to anchor India’s Intelligence Revolution”.

“In earlier centuries, nations built navies to secure trade routes. Today, we build sovereign compute to secure intelligence routes,” Jeet Adani, Executive Director, Adani Group, said.

BIG TECH’S OFFER
From the US, tech giants including Amazon, Google and Microsoft said they were prepared to deploy \$67.5 billion in AI and data centre infrastructure across India over the next five years.



A delegation of 120 American CEOs, including Alphabet/Google’s Sundar Pichai, Adobe Chair Shantanu Narayen, FedEx President Raj Subramaniam, Microsoft President Brad Smith and General Catalyst CEO Hemant Taneja, attended the Summit. The US tech giants position India

as a strategic AI hub.

Microsoft plans to invest \$50 billion by the end of this decade to expand AI across the Global South, Smith said.

GOOGLE’S PLAN
Google said it will spend \$30 million through Google.org AI for government Innovation Impact Challenge to support AI-powered government-to-citizen solutions, apart from its recent announcement of a \$15-billion AI Hub in Vizag.

Qualcomm Technologies said it will contribute up to ₹90 crore over the next five years to support the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) under a strategic collaboration to support mission-driven research programmes.

Qualcomm had earlier announced its intention to invest up to \$150 million to support India’s rapidly expanding technology and AI start-up ecosystem. The investments will be deployed through Qualcomm Ventures and will invest in start-ups across all stages.

Embraer, Mahindra plan MRO for C-390 if Brazilian co wins IAF deal

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Brazilian aerospace major Embraer and the Mahindra Group on Thursday announced plans to come together to establish a maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO) facility in India for the C-390 Millennium, provided the foreign original manufacturer (Embraer) is selected for the Indian Air Force’s Medium Transport Aircraft (MTA) programme.

The acquisition of MTA has been hanging fire since December 2022 when the Ministry of Defence issued a Request for Information for the transporter to replace the IAF’s ageing fleet of An-32 and Ilyushin IL-76, both of Russian origin.

Talks between India and Brazil have gathered momentum, with Brazil showing keen interest in participating once the Request for Proposal (RFP) is re-



HEAVY LIFTER. The C-390 Millennium is seen as a replacement for the IAF’s ageing transport fleet REUTERS

leased to initiate the formal acquisition process for the transporter aircraft.

The others in the race are Airbus (A400M) and Lockheed Martin (C-130J).

“The initiative reinforces the companies’ joint commitment to positioning the C-390 Millennium as a strong solution for India’s future medium transport aircraft requirements,” a statement released by Embraer and Mahindra read.

The two companies have already inked an agreement

for jointly bidding for up to 80 C-390s that the IAF requires for capability enhancement.

C-390 IN FOCUS
The proposed MRO facility, as per the partners, will provide comprehensive in-country maintenance and sustainment for the C-390 fleet, supporting high levels of operational readiness and availability.

Embraer said the C-390 Millennium has a payload capacity of up to 26 tonnes and has higher speed and

range than other medium-size military transport aircraft.

HIGH PAYLOAD EDGE
The C-390 can operate from temporary or unpaved runways and can be configured for air-to-air refuelling, both as a tanker and as a receiver.

“Embraer is committed to delivering not only a world-class aircraft, but also a robust, long-term support ecosystem tailored to India’s operational and industrial requirements,” said Bosco da Costa Junior, President and CEO, Embraer Defence and Security.

“A state-of-the-art C-390 Millennium MRO capability in India would ensure high aircraft availability, enhanced operational autonomy and a comprehensive local sustainment solution for the Indian Air Force throughout the aircraft’s lifecycle,” said Vinod Sahay, Member of the Group Executive Board, Mahindra Group.

Chinese walnuts ‘mis-declared’ as Afghan produce on container ship held at Nhava Sheva Port

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

At least 46 containers of the Comoros-flag vessel *WTV Reyfa* detained by the Customs at Nhava Sheva Port are reported to be carrying walnuts from China, but “mis-declared” as Afghan produce.

The ship, carrying 310 containers and claiming to have originated from Bandar Abbas Port in Iran, has been held up by the Customs over two-and-a-half weeks now.

Customs officials acted on “specific information” on mis-declaration of origin that the Department of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) received.

A circular issued by the Customs Intelligence Unit (CIU) on February 17 said one person was arrested in this connection, and investigations had revealed duty evasion of ₹50 crore. So far, no importer has come forward to identify the consignments.

US, CHILE WALNUTS TOO
“The vessel has been held up because of these 46 containers. Boxes containing walnuts have come from China, and the exporters



NUT CASE. This mis-declaration has been happening for years. Walnuts from the US and Chile have been entering as Afghan produce to claim the zero-duty benefit under SAFTA

did not even change the packages with Chinese markings,” said a Mumbai-based trade source, who did not wish to be identified.

“This mis-declaration has been happening for years. Walnuts from the US and Chile have been entering as Afghan produce to claim the zero-duty benefit under the South Asian Free Trade Agreement (SAFTA),” said a North Indian trader.

Walnuts from other origins, such as the US, have better kernel yield. Every kg of domestic walnut-in-shell yields 350 gm of kernels. In the case of the US or other countries, the yield is 450-500 gm.

India currently imposes a 100 per cent import duty

on walnuts to protect domestic growers, particularly from Kashmir. So, unscrupulous traders bring walnuts from other countries, claiming them to be from Afghanistan.

TRADE RIVALRY
“This time, the Customs acted because a section of traders gave specific information to the officials possibly due to business rivalry. It is not just the case with walnuts. It happens with arecanut and black cardamom also,” said the North Indian trader.

The *modus operandi* is that some traders purchase walnuts imported into one of the Gulf ports.

Then, these are shipped to ports such as Bandar Ab-

bas to claim zero-duty status under SAFTA.

“Similarly, arecanut from other growing countries, such as China, land in Colombo before being shipped to India to derive SAFTA benefits,” said the North Indian trader.

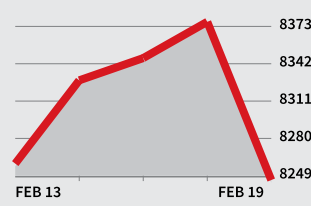
A South Indian trader said Chinese garlic was also finding its way into India in the same way.

Traders said since the shipment documents are submitted manually, it is easy to “manipulate” the origin of a product.

DOMESTIC PRICES
The CIU circular said to substantiate the false country of origin, traders forge transit documentation (House Bill of Lading) and upload in E-sanchit, ICES (an e-commerce portal of the Indian Customs Department). Thus, a false trail of movement of goods is created from ports such as Bandar Abbas to other ports, particularly in the Gulf, such as Jebel Ali.

On e-commerce websites, Kashmir walnuts in shell cost ₹450 a kg for the jumbo variety and about ₹350 for other varieties, while the Californian and Chilean varieties cost ₹560 and ₹700 respectively.

SENSEX 82498.14 (-1236.11)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	25454.35	-365.00
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	22.65	-0.34
US Dollar (in ₹)	---	---
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	153951.00	+2974
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	244772.00	+7974

AIMING HIGH.

Sarvam's goal is not to shoot for AGI, but to cater to a majority of governance and business use cases: Co-founder Vivek Raghavan **p3**



₹8,175 CR GIGA FACTORY.

Waaree Energies will set up a lithium-ion battery gigafactory in AP's Anakapalli district **p5**

Tech titans hail India as emerging AI rule-maker

BIG BET. Prime Minister Narendra Modi pitches country as a key player in the global race

Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi



UPBEAT MOOD. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, with Google CEO Sundar Pichai (left) and OpenAI CEO Sam Altman at the India AI Impact Summit 2026 in New Delhi **p11**

The AI Summit on Thursday saw the cream of global tech titans celebrate India's progress in artificial intelligence with CEOs highlighting India's role as not just a power user of AI, but also a rule maker demonstrating how AI can be used to achieve critical outcomes. Predicting rapid strides in the next few years, the leaders also called on India to lead the way on regulations.

Google's Sundar Pichai, OpenAI's Sam Altman, Anthropic's Dario Amodei, Mistral's Arthur Mensch, Microsoft's Brad Smith and DeepMind's Demis Hassabis were among the star speakers who hailed India's rapid strides in AI, and said the country is setting an example in using the tech to solve real world problems, both at scale and in a responsible manner.

"India's leadership in sovereign AI, building on infrastructure, SLMs and much more, has been great to watch. It is also striking how

much progress India has made in its mission to put AI to work for people," OpenAI CEO Altman said.

MANAV VISION

In his inaugural address, Prime Minister Narendra Modi pitched India as a key player in the global AI race, and called for democratisation of the technology.

He laid down his MANAV (moral and ethical system; accountable governance; national sovereignty, accessible and inclusive technology; and valid and legitimate systems) vision for AI.

Along with Modi, French President Emmanuel Macron and UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres also stressed that the future of AI cannot be decided by a handful of countries, and real impact comes from improving the lives of people. Macron also praised the growth of India's digital public infrastructure in the last 10 years.

Infosys' Nandan Nilekani and Anthropic's Dario Amodei concurred in a panel discussion that India can set an example of AI-powered economic growth but said 'diffusion' of the technology

should be the key focus of policymakers to achieve this.

Others like Microsoft President Brad Smith said India can show the path for AI growth in the Global South. "AI should be made as effective in every language as it is in English, and we must invest more in better quality of data in various forms."

INDIA INC'S BIG PLANS

Indian business leaders including Reliance Industries' Mukesh Ambani, Tata's N Chandrasekaran and Adani Group's Jeet Adani reiterated their commitment to grow the ecosystem with more investments in sovereign compute capacity, and said their mission was to put AI in the hands of every individual.

IT service honchos, including Wipro's Rishad Premji and Accenture's Julie Sweet, highlighted India's role as an AI destination, and the quality of its talent. "Companies, countries and individuals must reinvent how they work, how they work together and how they learn," Sweet said.

More reports p2, p3, p4

Stocks sink as crude rises on fears of US-Iran conflict; gains of 3 days gone

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Stock markets saw a sharp reversal on Thursday, wiping out three sessions of gains to close at their lowest since February 3, as a flare-up in tensions between the US and Iran pushed up crude prices.

The Nifty 50 plunged 365 points and the BSE Sensex shed 1,236.11 points.

Reports of a possible US military action on Iran drove Brent crude to a year-to-date high, stoking inflationary fears around a possible bottlenecking of the Strait of Hormuz.

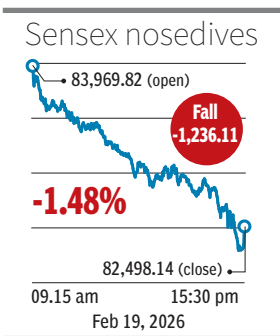
Vinod Nair, Head of Research at Geojit Investments, said the sell-off was

further aggravated by "low FII participation because of the Lunar New Year holiday across key Asian markets and a non-settlement day on account of a regional banking holiday in India," alongside a weaker rupee and uncertainty over the US Fed's rate-cut trajectory.

SECTORAL ROUT

Of Nifty's 50 stocks, all, except three, ended in the red. IndiGo was the top loser, falling 3.28 per cent; UltraTech Cement dropped 2.97 per cent and M&M lost 2.93 per cent.

All sectoral indices ended in the red. Nifty Realty, Media and Auto took the sharpest cut. Nifty Bank fell 1.32 per cent. Nifty Next 50



dropped 1.86 per cent while Nifty Midcap 100 declined 1.59 per cent to 59,227.65, and Nifty Smallcap 100 shed 1.27 per cent.

Stocks at 52-week lows (146) exceeded those at 52-week highs (110).

PL Asset Management

said in a note that markets appear to be "transitioning from correction to early recovery," pointing to valuations at 19-20x earnings and the India-US trade deal, which cut tariffs on Indian goods from 50 per cent to 18 per cent, as near-term catalysts.

GOLD, SILVER WATCH

MCX gold held near ₹1.55-1.56 lakh per 10 g, with the upside capped by profit-taking and delayed rate-cut expectations.

Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst at LKP Securities, said the US-Iran talks "failed to yield a constructive outcome, reigniting military tensions and prompting fresh buying".

SC criticises States over freebie culture

Krishnadas Rajagopal
New Delhi



The Supreme Court on Thursday chastised State governments for distributing freebies indiscriminately without even distinguishing between the haves and the have-nots, questioning if they are following an "appeasement" policy without a thought for the public exchequer ahead of elections.

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, heading a three-judge Bench, said States, even revenue-surplus ones, must prioritise welfare and development over irrational largesse. Despite running on deficit, the CJI said, the States seemed to still have money to randomly splurge on largesse.

The court asked whether the States had a tested mechanism to distribute welfare effectively, to those who actually need a "helping hand".

ADVANTAGE AFFLUENT

"Is it not your obligation to spend money to develop infrastructure, roads, hospitals, schools, medical colleges? Instead you keep

giving scooties, you distribute clothes, food at the time of elections. What is happening in this country," the Chief Justice asked.

The court said largesse was distributed in such a way that the most affluent get them first.

"It is understandable that some people cannot afford, the State has to provide. There are children who cannot afford education. You must provide. It is their fundamental right. There are many bright children who cannot afford higher education."

"It is the State's duty to extend a helping hand to them. That is welcome. But for people who do not deserve, those who are affluent, why give them freebies? Why do freebies come to their

pockets first? Is it not high time for the States to revisit these policies," Chief Justice Kant asked.

TN DISCOM PLEA

The Bench, also comprising Justices Joydalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi, was hearing a writ petition filed by the Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Limited (TNPDC), represented by senior advocates Gopal Subramaniam and P Wilson, challenging the constitutional validity of Rule 23 of the Electricity (Amendment) Act, 2024.

The Chief Justice asked why the State's policy did not allow the government to generate profits from the power sector by making the affluent sections pay for the electricity they consume.

Subramaniam said these are matters of governance, and there ought to be a sort of equity in matters of allocation of resources.

"Why should State governments, be it Haryana or Punjab or Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan or the North-Eastern States, have so much statesmanship? We know what is happening in States when

elections come up. Why suddenly schemes are announced? High time all political stalwarts, leaders, political parties and ideologues revisit everything... We will be hampering the larger welfare obligations of the government if we keep on distributing largesse without a care. There has to be a balance," Chief Justice Kant observed.

The court said distribution of largesse short-sightedly ultimately affect the poor, whose children need welfare schemes and funds to study in good schools and go to good hospitals where medical care is not exorbitantly high.

At one point, the court proposed that the government file an affidavit as to from where they would source the funds for welfare and development.

However, after a brief conference among the judges on the Bench, Chief Justice Kant addressed the Tamil Nadu side, saying the court did not want to "cross our limitations and comment or decide on the purpose of a welfare scheme or how it should be given".



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QUICKLY.

JioHotstar launches ChatGPT-powered service

Mumbai: JioHotstar announced a ChatGPT-powered voice discovery streaming assistant in partnership with OpenAI on Thursday. The rollout will span both live and on-demand formats, beginning with select experiences and expanding in phases. Audiences can now discover, engage with different languages and genres through multilingual cognitive search, replacing scroll fatigue with meaningful, human-centric discovery. **OUR BUREAU**

Switzerland to host next edition of AI summit

New Delhi: Swiss President Guy Parmelin on Thursday announced that his country is looking forward to hosting the next edition of the AI summit in Geneva in 2027. Parmelin is among around 20 global leaders attending the ongoing AI Impact Summit in New Delhi. “Switzerland is looking forward to hosting the 2027 AI Summit in Geneva, and to working with the subsequent incoming host of the 2028 AI Summit, the UAE, as partner for the Geneva summit,” he said. **PTI**

OpenAI CEO applauds India’s progress in sovereign AI, SLMs

PLAYING IT SAFE. Proposes creation of an international coordination body for regulation

Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi

OpenAI CEO Sam Altman on Thursday recognised India’s significant leadership in advanced artificial intelligence (AI), noting the country’s progress in sovereign AI, infrastructure and small language models (SLMs). This comes just three years after he suggested during a prior visit that India did not have the ability to engage in the global AI model development space.

‘WELL-POSITIONED’

“India, the world’s largest democracy, is well-positioned to lead in AI, not just build it, to shape it and decide what our future is going to look like,” said Altman in his keynote address at the AI Impact Summit.

He also flagged a need to move quickly on this goal.

“On our current trajectory, we believe we may be



TECH EVANGELIST. OpenAI CEO Sam Altman addressing a gathering during the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi on Thursday

only a couple of years away from early versions of true superintelligence,” he said.

By the end of 2028, more of the world’s intellectual capacity could reside within data centres than outside of them, he said, adding that AI is capable of performing better research than the top scientists or even serving more effectively than a CEO like

him. On what this means for society at large, Altman admitted that while AI brings faster economic growth, it will also cause significant job disruption.

“Technology always disrupts jobs. We always find new and better things to do,” he argued.

“The specifics of what we do day-to-day will probably

look very different. Each generation has built on the work of the generations before,” he said.

Outlining three central requirements for navigating this period of transition, Altman said democratisation of AI is key, and the centralisation of technology in a single entity or country could lead to ruin. Second, there is a need for societal resilience, he said.

He also advocated for iterative deployment. “Society needs to contend with and use each successive new level of AI capability, have time to integrate it, understand it and decide how to move forward,” he said.

Altman stressed that regulation and safeguards are urgently needed, and proposed the creation of an international coordination body, similar to the International Atomic Energy Agency. “We can choose to either empower people or concentrate power,” he said.

‘We must democratise AI so that humans don’t become just data points’



SHARING IS CARING. India believes AI will benefit the world only when it is shared, said Prime Minister Narendra Modi

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Thursday that it is important to democratise artificial intelligence (AI) so that humans don’t end up being reduced to data points or treated solely as raw material.

“We need to democratise AI. We need to make it a means for inclusion and empowerment, especially in the Global South... We also need to provide an open sky for AI and keep command in our hands just like GPS that suggests our route, but we take the final call on which direction to take,” said Modi here at the inaugural session of the India AI Impact Summit 2026.

Modi remarked that India’s vision for AI is clearly reflected in the theme of the summit — ‘Welfare for all, happiness of all’ — and emphasised that this is the benchmark for India.

Regarding jobs, he noted that the future of work in AI is not pre-defined, but will depend on collective decisions and actions. “The future of work is a new opportunity, marking an era where humans and intelligent systems co-create, co-work and co-evolve.”

He underlined that AI will make work smarter, more efficient and more impactful, enabling better design, faster

building and improved decision-making.

“AI will also open higher-value, creative and meaningful roles for more people, creating opportunities for innovation, entrepreneurship and new industries. We have to make skilling, reskilling and lifelong learning a mass movement,” he said.

OPEN CODE

Modi also highlighted that transparency is the greatest safeguard. He said while some countries and companies consider AI a strategic asset to be developed confidentially, India believes AI will benefit the world only when it is shared.

He emphasised on open code and collaborative development, which will allow millions of young minds to make AI better and safer.

He also noted that there is an urgent need for global standards because of deep-fakes and fabricated content that are destabilising open societies.

“Just like we see nutrition labels on food, digital content too must carry authenticity labels so that people can distinguish between real and AI-generated material. There is a growing need for watermarking and clear source standards, as AI increasingly generates text, images and videos, to build trust into technology from the start,” he said.

AI could power 25% economic growth in India: Anthropic CEO

Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi

India is a perfect case study to prove that artificial intelligence can accelerate economic growth, given its technical potential around the technology, said Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei on Thursday. He was speaking at a panel discussion at the AI Impact Summit with Infosys’ Co-founder Nandan Nilekani.

“It may sound absurd but AI can even help India achieve a standout 25 per cent economic growth, and India can be one of the countries in the world that most embodies the benefits of the

technology,” said Amodei.

PROBLEM-SOLVER

He added that the Global South has an opportunity to prove that AI can solve real problems, and India, as one of the world’s largest democracies, can show how democracies can handle AI.

Quipping that even a 10 per cent growth would be great, Nilekani said diffusion of AI will play a key role to achieve this.

“Right now there is a race to the top and race to the bottom in AI,” said Nilekani. “All of us have a responsibility to make AI diffusion happen, else there is going to be a backlash and social resentment. Resentment of the



POSITIVE VIBES. Nandan Nilekani, co-founder, Infosys (left), and Dario Amodei, CEO, Anthropic, at the AI summit on Thursday

white collar worker may lead to a train wreck of AI,” he stressed.

Amodei acknowledged that currently there is a duality between the fundamental

capabilities of the technology and the time it takes for those capabilities to diffuse into the world. “There are just frictions to adopt things through enterprises, even

more so in the developing world,” he said.

“I think, in India, we have a little bit of experience with that [diffusion] with 1.4 billion people on Aadhaar, 500 billion people on UPI, 20 billion transactions a month, the world’s largest cash transfer system, the largest financial inclusion system, you name it,” said Nilekani.

“For all the investments of AI to deliver value to society, we have to look at diffusion pathways for AI; India must focus on becoming the use capital for AI,” he added. “Technology is just one piece of the puzzle. It’s about institutions. It’s about trust building. It’s about negotiations. It’s about guardrails.”

GLOBAL SYNERGY



UNITED FOR A CAUSE. Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Google CEO Sundar Pichai, OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, Meta Chief AI Officer Alexandr Wang and other dignitaries at the AI Impact Summit 2026 in New Delhi on Thursday **ANI**

Tata, TCS, OpenAI in multi-year deal to develop AI infrastructure

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

The Tata Group, Tata Consultancy Services’ (TCS) HyperVault unit and OpenAI have agreed to a multi-year partnership to develop AI infrastructure in India.

TCS will develop AI infrastructure with 100MW capacity, with an option to scale to 1 GW to power next-generation AI workloads. TCS will leverage OpenAI’s Codex to boost software engineering outcomes.

ACCESS TO CHAT GPT

All Tata Group employees will get access to Enterprise ChatGPT, while the two companies will provide AI training and resources to Indian youth, enabling them to apply AI responsibly and efficiently at scale. They will develop technology toolkits for NGOs and launch initiatives

focused on at least one million Indian youth.

“All Tata Group employees will have access to Enterprise ChatGPT, while the two companies will provide AI training and resources to Indian youth, enabling them to apply AI responsibly and efficiently at scale. They will develop technology toolkits for NGOs and launch initiatives focused on reaching at least one million Indian youth,” said Sam Altman, CEO, OpenAI.

“Through OpenAI for India and our partnership with the Tata Group, we’re working together to build the infrastructure, skills and local partnerships needed to build AI with India, for India and in India, so that more people across the country can access and benefit from it,” added Altman.

“This deep collaboration between OpenAI and the Tata Group marks a major

milestone in India’s vision to become a global leader in AI.

We are pleased to partner with OpenAI to create state-of-the-art AI infrastructure in India. This is a unique opportunity for OpenAI and TCS to transform industries. Together, we will skill India’s youth and empower them to succeed in the AI era,” said N Chandrasekaran, Chairman, Tata Sons.

‘NOT COMMON’

Reacting to the development, Yugal Joshi, Partner, Everest Group, told *businessline*: “Normally such partnerships mean system integrators adopting technologies of frontier AI companies. However, jointly investing in core AI infrastructure, is not common. It will be crucial to see these announcements reach fruition because they are prone to fizzle out due to procedural, regulatory and partnership issues.”

When Altman and Amodei’s uneasy hand clasp spoke louder than words

Our Bureau
New Delhi

It was a fleeting moment of awkwardness that stole the spotlight at the AI Summit on Thursday. As a show of boisterous bonhomie, Prime Minister Narendra Modi beamed as he urged a line-up of global technology leaders to raise their clasped hands for a celebratory photograph.

The purple backdrop, emblazoned with circuitry motifs and the promise of artificial intelligence, framed what was meant to be a tableau of unity.

But as the cameras clicked, a subtle gap remained. To the Prime Minister’s right stood Sam Altman of OpenAI. Next to him was Dario Amodei, who leads rival firm An-

thropic. Both men raised their arms dutifully for the photo-op.

BREAKING THE CHAIN

Yet the clasped chain of hands, so enthusiastically initiated by Modi, did not quite bridge the competitive divide between two of the industry’s most closely-watched adversaries. So they both raised their hands, but refused to clasp them together, breaking the chain so enthusiastically started by Modi (see photo above).

“I did not know what was happening,” said Altman when asked about the moment.

“I was sort of confused. [Prime Minister] Modi grabbed my hand and put it up, and I just was not sure what we were supposed to be

Altman and Amodei are not merely executives attending the same conference circuit. Their companies compete at the cutting edge of large language models and enterprise contracts

doing. I thought it was the o’clock,” the OpenAI CEO was quoted as saying by *PTI*.

The hesitation was brief, almost imperceptible. But in a sector defined by intense rivalry, billion-dollar valuations and a race to dominate

the frontier of generative AI, symbolism matters.

SHARED HISTORY

Altman and Amodei are not merely executives attending the same conference circuit. Their companies compete at the cutting edge of large language models, enterprise contracts and global influence over how AI systems are built and governed.

Anthropic itself was founded by former OpenAI executives, including Amodei, after internal differences over strategy and safety.

Earlier this month, Altman and Amodei took swipes at each other after Anthropic aired a Super Bowl campaign in the US that appeared to mock OpenAI’s move to introduce ads in ChatGPT.

Altman, who believes in

democratising technology rather than keeping it behind paywalls, did not take the jibe kindly.

“Anthropic serves an expensive product to rich people,” Altman shot back on X.

“We are glad they do that, and we are doing that too, but we also feel strongly that we need to bring AI to billions of people who can’t pay for subscriptions,” he added.

REALITY SPEAKS

So, while Modi’s gesture was meant to project solidarity in India’s AI ambitions, the body language on stage reflected a more nuanced reality — collaboration in policy forums, competition in the marketplace.

To be sure, no public words were exchanged and

no visible friction followed. The two leaders stood composed, suits immaculate, expressions neutral. The choreography of global tech diplomacy resumed almost immediately.

Yet, in an era where AI summits increasingly double as stages for geopolitical theatre, even small gestures carry weight.

The photograph will likely circulate as intended: World leaders and tech titans united under the banner of AI progress.

But for those who follow Silicon Valley’s shifting alliances, the split-second reluctance offered a reminder that while governments may call for collective advancement, the race for AI supremacy remains intensely personal.

Andhra Pradesh CM to attend AI summit today

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu will attend the India AI Impact Summit 2026 at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi on Friday. The Chief Minister will participate in meetings with industrial leaders, during which several agreements will be signed.

He will take part in the plenary session titled *AI Accelerators: Fuelling India’s Economic Growth*, along with Assam Chief Minister Hemanta Biswa Sarma, Union Minister Jitin Prasada and representatives from TCS.

The State government will sign agreements to strengthen AI infrastructure

and skill development, including with technology major IBM and the United Nations International Computing Centre (UNICC), which provides information technology and digital business solutions.

UNICC will help the State establish a Quantum and AI Centre of Excellence.

businessline.

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QUICKLY.

Fractal unveils Vaidya 2.0 healthcare model



Mumbai: Fractal AI on Thursday launched Vaidya 2.0, the next generation of its healthcare reasoning models, at the India AI Impact Summit 2026. Vaidya 2.0 links healthcare action with raw data and enhances model capabilities for enabling real-world healthcare use-cases, including Emergency Assist for rapid triage and decision support in critical windows; symptom checker, providing high-fidelity reasoning for citizen-facing wellness; and patient journey assist. “It is the first AI model in the world to achieve 50+ score on OpenAI’s HealthBench (hard),” said Fractal in a release. OUR BUREAU

AI GI and Nvidia to support 500 new Indian AI start-ups

Mumbai: AI Grants India (AIGI), India’s AI-focused non-profit organisation, announced a collaboration with Nvidia to support up to 500 new AI start-ups from India through the Nvidia Inception programme for start-ups. Under the initiative, over 10,000 early-stage founders will have access to advanced AI tools and enablement programming over the next 12 months to help teams move from concept to product faster. “India’s next wave of AI innovation will be built by early teams that have the technical depth to execute, but need faster access to the right tooling, mentorship and ecosystem pathways. This collaboration is designed to help more founders move from idea to product, at a national Scale,” said Bhasker (Bosky) Kode, Co-founder, AIGI. OUR BUREAU

NATIONS IN SYNC



WHEN LEADERS CONNECT. Prime Minister Narendra Modi with French President Emmanuel Macron, Brazilian President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, Serbian President Aleksandar Vucic, Netherlands’ PM Dick Schoof, Mauritius’ PM Navinchandra Ramgoolam, Kazakhstan’s PM Olzhas Bektenov, Greece’s PM Kyriakos Mitsotakis, Finland’s PM Petteri Orpo, Croatian PM Andrej Plenkovic, Bhutan’s PM Tshering Tobgay and other global leaders at the AI Impact Summit 2026 in New Delhi on Thursday ANI

Only thing that prevents us from getting to a very large model size is capital: Sarvam Co-founder

bl.interview

Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi

Sarvam’s goal is not to shoot for AGI, but to cater to a majority of the governance and business use cases of India, the company’s Co-founder Vivek Raghavan said. “What we have launched is a significant first step. We can build LLMs, maybe not at the scale of Gemini or Anthropic or ChatGPT, but we can build models as good as anything in the world,” he said.

He credits Sarvam’s recent successes to a small group of around 20 young and highly-skilled engineers who put in the long hours and dataset innovation to get here, and says they took both criticism and success in a tempered manner.

Edited excerpts:

How significant are



I want to stress that it is the young kids in our company who have burnt the midnight oil to actually make this happen

VIVEK RAGHAVAN,
Co-founder,
Sarvam

Sarvam’s achievements in terms of the various products you launched this week?

We are at the beginning of this journey. All that we have launched shows that India can build small models in voice and vision, which are the best in the world.

And AI is a space where sovereignty is important. I also want to stress that it is the young kids in our company who have burnt the midnight oil to actually make this happen.

They put in a significant amount of work and innovation to actually create the



data sets required to do this, as well as to train the models. And I think that’s something the youth of the country should believe that they can do this.

What’s next for Sarvam?

Now we want to get these models into the hands of people. So far, we have been working mainly with enterprises in a B2B2C kind of configuration. We will be looking at the government’s citizen outreach and service efficiencies.

We will also have some ways that people can directly

experience some of these models to a certain extent. But, there I’m competing with large players like ChatGPT or Gemini who have billions of investment, so it’s very hard for me to do that at a large scale.

Will you stop at this model size?

The only thing that prevents us from getting to a very large model size is capital. There’s no doubt that we will need more funding.

Yes, there is a lot of in-bound interest because of what we have shown. But there is still a question of whether someone is going to back the building of a frontier model out of India.

I don’t see anything else in the longer run that prevents us from building for the world from India. We have to figure out the right way.

How do you see this moment changing Indian tech?

The fact that we’re able to train a model like this shows that India can do this.

I’m hoping that the best people from all over the world see the success and try to come and become part of the Sarvam story to show that we can build deep tech out of India.

What inspired you and your co-founder to start Sarvam?

For 15 years before starting Sarvam, I was a full-time volunteer building Aadhaar, working on Bhashini, and other digital public infrastructure.

But then, when ChatGPT happened, we knew we had to move fast to do this in India.

When you look at something like UPI, right, for the first time, we feel that some service in our country is better than the world, and why can’t this be the case for everything? I think AI provides that light at the end of the tunnel.

‘Govt is aware of challenges faced by the IT industry’

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Minister of Electronics and Information Technology Ashwini Vaishnaw on Thursday said that the government was fully aware of the challenges that the Indian IT industry is facing due to artificial intelligence (AI) and is working with academia to upskill and reskill talent.

Speaking at the inaugural session of the India AI Impact Summit 2026, Vaishnaw said that the Prime Minister, through the recent Budget, announced a major policy shift aimed at attracting the world’s data to India, to reside in India, to be processed here and to deliver high-value services to the world.

TALENT PIPELINE

“We are conscious of the challenges which our IT industry is facing and to mitigate them, we are working with the industry and academia to upskill, reskill and build a new talent pipeline for this new intelligence age,” he said.

He said AI is a foundational technology that is already transforming how we work, learn and make decisions. “Our Prime Minister



Union IT Minister
Ashwini Vaishnaw PTI

believes that the true value of technology lies in ensuring that it benefits reach the masses. His vision is to democratise technology, deploy it at scale and make it accessible to all,” Vaishnaw noted.

He highlighted that the Summit has participation from 118 countries.

CLEAN ENERGY PUSH

Vaishnaw also said the Prime Minister had always shown commitment towards clean energy, and that India currently has over 50 per cent of its power generation capacity from clean sources.

“Our visionary Prime Minister has recently reformed the nuclear energy sector, which is another critical source for providing base load clean energy,” he said.

“We have a robust grid which has been practically rebuilt over the last decade,” he added.

Bill Gates pulls out of keynote address at AI Impact Summit

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Microsoft Co-Founder Bill Gates pulled out of his scheduled keynote address in the AI Impact Summit on Thursday.

The move came amid scrutiny and backlash on social media over his India visit and his inclusion on the summit agenda, despite his alleged links to Jeffrey Epstein.

In a post on X, the Gates

Foundation India stated, “After careful consideration, and to ensure the focus remains on the AI Summit’s key priorities, Mr. Gates will not be delivering his keynote address. The Gates Foundation will be represented by Ankur Vora, President of Africa and India Offices, who will speak later today at the Summit. The Gates Foundation remains fully committed to our work in India to advance our shared health and development goals.”

India’s AI future hinges on sovereignty: Jeet Adani

Avinash Nair
New Delhi

India’s AI journey will be defined not by adoption, but by ownership, said Jeet Adani, Director of Adani Digital Labs, at the AI Impact Summit on Thursday. In a geopolitically charged era, he argued that without sovereignty over energy, computing and AI services, capability risks sliding into foreign dependence.

“AI is no longer just software; it is infrastructure, energy and national strategy,” he said, pointing out that relying on foreign systems exposes the country to vulnerabilities in a century where technology and geopolitics are inseparable,” he said.

“If a nation’s energy systems are fragile, its intelligence systems are fragile. In today’s AI era, power grids and data grids are inseparable,” Adani added, underscoring the link between energy sovereignty and intelligence sovereignty.

Adani highlighted that In-



If a nation’s energy systems are fragile, its intelligence systems are fragile. In today’s AI era, power grids and data grids are inseparable

JEET ADANI

Director of Adani Digital Labs



dia must build its own intelligence systems rather than plug into foreign ones. “India must host critical AI workloads domestically,” he said, emphasising that control over compute is no longer optional but a strategic national priority. The stakes are high: countries that secure their AI infrastructure gain decisive advantages in productivity, security, and technological leadership.

THREE PILLARS

Adani outlined three pillars of AI sovereignty critical for India’s long-term positioning. Energy sovereignty links

renewable power directly to AI data centres, ensuring reliability under peak loads and turning green energy expansion into a strategic advantage.

Compute and cloud sovereignty calls for domestic hosting of high-performance AI workloads across start-ups, academia, healthcare, manufacturing, and defence to avoid external vulnerabilities.

Services sovereignty focuses on applying AI to amplify India’s domestic productivity — from agriculture and education to rural healthcare, logistics, and en-

ergy distribution. Framing AI sovereignty as modern nationalism, Adani stressed that India’s AI revolution must first benefit its citizens before generating global margins. “AI must become a force multiplier for Indian citizens before it becomes a margin multiplier for others,” he said, highlighting the Adani Group’s \$100 billion pledge to build a sovereign, green-energy-powered AI platform — an integrated ecosystem combining 5 GW of renewable energy and hyperscale computing.

For Adani, the challenge is urgent. “Inclusion without capability is weakness, and capability without sovereignty is foreign dependence,” he said, driving home the need for India to secure its AI infrastructure. In his view, the AI century will favour nations that integrate energy, computing and services control into a unified domestic ecosystem, giving India the chance to shape its technology, productivity, and strategic autonomy for decades to come.

Macron asks India to join the coalition to make the internet and social media safe for children

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

French President Emmanuel Macron on Thursday called on India to work with France to take measures to protect children against the harmful effects of social media and AI. Stressing the need for a sovereign AI path, he added that at a time when AI has become a major area of strategic competition, there is an increased sense of urgency to direct all digital tools towards an inclusive approach.

Addressing the AI Impact Summit, Macron said, “There is no reason our children should be exposed online to what is legally forbidden in the real world. One of our priorities during the G-7 presidency will be children’s protection against AI and digital-related abuse. Our platforms, governments and regulators should be working together to make the inter-



French President Emmanuel Macron delivering a plenary speech at the Summit ANI

net and social media a safe space.”

GLOBAL COALITION

He called on Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi to join the initiative, stating there was a need for a “new coalition of the willing.” This comes at a time when India has said it’s working on age-based restrictions with social media companies.

“I know, Mr Prime Minister, you will join this club. This is great news that India will join such an approach to

protect children and teenagers,” he said while highlighting France’s initiative to ban social media networks for children under 15. European nations, including the UK and Germany, are also looking at similar social media bans for minors,

Pointing to the shift in the AI landscape over the past year, Macron said that AI and GPUs are now directly translated into geopolitical and macroeconomic terms. “At a time when tensions are rising, there is an increased sense of urgency to direct all our digital tools towards this inclusive approach,” he said. Macron pointed out that the “smartest AI” will not be the one that is most expensive, but it will be the one that is built by the “best people” for the “right purpose”.

COMMON VISION

Macron said France and India share a common vision for developing a “sovereign

AI” to protect the planet and foster prosperity for all.

“AI may be a powerful accelerator of productivity and a major shift for labour markets. This is why access to AI for all is critical... The future of AI will be built by those who combine innovation and responsibility and technology with humanity and India and France will help to shape this future together,” he added.

ALLIED ACTION

“I have come to convey that we are determined to continue to shape the rules of the game. And to do with our allies, such as India, because we believe in core shared values, science, rule of law, global balance, multilateralism and innovation for the benefit of all. Now is the time to channel our forces towards what works. Concrete action and solutions that make AI more sustainable, efficient and accessible,” Macron stated.

‘India can be a place where a lot of AI innovation can start’

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Emphasising that India has all the ingredients to effect a transformation leveraging AI, Schneider Electric’s Global CEO Olivier Blum on Thursday noted that the world’s third-largest energy consumer can be the platform from which the next big innovation in artificial intelligence (AI) can take place.

Speaking at the AI Impact Summit 2026, Blum said, “The level of innovation in India, some people call it *jugaad*, but the level of creativity that you can have in India to create a new system that will solve the most complex problem of the planet. When you look at the number of engineers you have in power, automation, digital, you have all the ingredients which are together at a point in time where we need to



Olivier Blum, Global CEO, Schneider Electric BLOOMBERG

make AI a big transformation for the planet.”

POWER DEMAND

Blum opined that access to reliable and clean power is an issue not just for India, but also for the world.

“AI means more compute. More computing means more energy. We don’t know exactly what is going to take, but it is going to put pressure on energy systems, which have nothing to do with what they are today,” he ex-

plained. Energy is a priority for the government and for the world. It’s even a geopolitical topic. The world is entering a new era where AI can transform the planet. However, the real question is how the energy system can navigate to the next level, and what AI can offer to make energy more efficient, he emphasised.

“India has a lot of factors which are different from the rest of the world. India is one of the countries where equipments are under tremendous pressure, more than in any other country. Second, India is an extremely cost-competitive country where you need to bring the best innovation at the best price. Third, the level of creativity that you can have in India to create new systems that will solve the most complex problems of the planet,” Blum noted.

Emphasising India’s im-

portance for the company, he said that India is the third largest country for Schneider Electric. It accounts for the largest employee base, around 40,000, for the company.

“You don’t know it, but India is the largest R&D centre we have in the world, with 8,000 employees, the largest number of software engineers. A new technology revolution, which is called AI, where India can be the place where a lot of innovation starts,” Blum said.

COMPUTE DEMAND

Elaborating on the data centre dynamics, he said, “About a couple of years ago, a couple of kilowatts per rack were there in the data centre. Then it moved to 10-30 KW. What we are building right now in India is something which is already around 80 kilowatts (kw) per rack, even more. And what we are doing

in the US right now with the GPU, which is available for Nvidia, is already at 150 KW.”

“I can go to 500 kw, to 1 megawatt, and that (will) put tremendous pressure on energy systems. It will force every single company to reinvent the energy system. I’m sure some of you have heard about the concept of 800-volt DC, which is the new type of electrical architecture you will need to have for the data centre of tomorrow that would be able to power the AI industry.”

On the advantages of AI, Blum said that Schneider Electric believes the world is entering a new era where power systems can be connected. If the physical and the digital worlds are connected seamlessly and can share usage data, then there can be significant savings in terms of power consumption in every single application.

AI tutors, doctors and agronomists should reach masses via Aadhaar-like system: Khosla

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

AI must be deployed at a population scale to every citizen through an Aadhaar-like identity backbone if it is to meaningfully benefit India’s bottom half, said Vinod Khosla, Founder of Khosla Ventures and Co-founder of Sun Microsystems.

Speaking at the India AI summit, he said, “Unless AI benefits the bottom half of the Indian population, there won’t be much impact.” He outlined a model in which AI-powered tutors, doctors and PhD-level agronomists are made universally accessible.

He pointed to the rapid uptake of AI tutors. Globally, about 400 million students have used free AI content and AI tutors, while in India, four million students have directly



Vinod Khosla, Founder of Khosla Ventures & Co-founder of Sun Microsystems

benefited, and more than 12 million use such tools regularly. Khosla said these AI tutors are built on billions of student questions from the CK-12 non-profit platform and are designed to adapt to individual learning gaps through knowledge tracing.

He added that his team is working with Sarvam AI to reimagine DIKSHA — India’s large but underutilised digital content repository — into a “DIKSHA 3.0” AI-first platform. The initiative would

also include professional development curricula to help teachers stay current.

In healthcare, Khosla said AI doctors capable of providing full primary care, chronic disease management, mental health therapy, physical therapy and nutrition coaching are already feasible. Available 24x7 at minimal cost, such systems could exceed the comprehensiveness of care accessible even in advanced economies, he argued.

Khosla suggested these AI-based services should be embedded into the Aadhaar ecosystem, leveraging the identity infrastructure that enabled UPI’s scale.

Extending the model to agriculture, Khosla said every farmer could have access to a PhD-level agronomist via AI, available round the clock and integrated with identity-linked services.

QUICKLY.

Pichai visits Coffee Board stall at AI Impact Summit

New Delhi: Google CEO Sundar Pichai on Thursday visited the Commerce Ministry's Coffee Board stall at the AI Impact Summit here. Savouring Malabar Arabica, Pichai interacted with baristas and experienced the flavours of India's premium GI-tagged coffees. The Ministry said many international delegates visited the stall to savour the sustainably shade-grown and naturally sun-dried Bharat GI coffees. [PH](#)

India must transition to IP-led nation: HCL head

New Delhi: India's technology sector must transition from scale-driven growth to an AI-focused, intelligence-led, and Intellectual Property (IP)-driven model, said Roshni Nadar Malhotra, Chairperson, HCL Technologies, on Thursday. "India must move from being a tech services-led nation to an IP-led nation; services scale with effort. IP scales infinitely," she said at the AI Impact Summit. She said future belongs not to those who merely deploy technology, but to those who build, own and shape platforms, models and products. [PH](#)

Impact on India greater than on other nations

New Delhi: The implications of AI in India will be more significant than anywhere in the world over the next few years, given its large population, and the country can play a global leadership role in data, privacy and security, Adobe Chairman and CEO Shantanu Narayen said on Thursday. India is better positioned when it comes to democratising AI and making it available for the masses, Narayen said here at the AI Impact Summit. [PH](#)

Jio, Reliance to invest ₹10 lakh cr over 7 years for AI transformation: Ambani

AFFORDABLE TECH. Reliance Chairman says Jio will connect India to the AI age at a reduced cost

Vallari Sanzgiri

Jio with Reliance will invest ₹10 lakh crore over the next seven years starting 2026 towards AI transformation and connect India to the 'Intelligence era,' said Mukesh Dhirubhai Ambani, Chairman and Managing Director, Reliance, during a keynote address at the India AI Summit.

Describing the investment as a "patient, disciplined, nation-building capital" to create durable economic value and strategic resilience for the next six decades, Ambani said, "India will emerge as one of the greatest AI powers in the world in the 21st century. In the coming decades no country in the world can match



EMPOWERING THE FUTURE. Mukesh Ambani, Chairman, Reliance Industries, at the AI Impact Summit [BLOOMBERG](#)

India's strength in demography, democracy, development, digital infrastructure, data generation and AI harvest."

Ambani said Jio will connect India to the AI age at a reduced cost, considering that India cannot afford to rent intelligence.

"We will reduce the cost of intelligence as dramatically as we did the cost of data," said Ambani.

COMPUTE INFRA Accordingly, Reliance's AI arm, Jio Intelligence, will create a sovereign compute infrastructure by building

gigawatt-scale data centres, using in-house energy resources and providing intelligence at edge.

The company is currently establishing a multi-gigawatt, AI-ready data-centres at Jamnagar.

"Over 120 MW will come online in the second half of 2026 this year, and a clear path to gigawatt-scale compute for training and large-scale inference," said Ambani.

Reliance will also use its in-house energy of up to 10 GW of ready green-power surplus, anchored by solar in both Kutch and Andhra Pradesh towards providing nationwide edge compute.

"An edge-compute layer, deeply integrated with Jio's network, will make intelligence responsive, low-latency and affordable —

close to where Indians live, learn and work. Our resolve is clear: make intelligence as ubiquitous as connectivity. When compute becomes infrastructure, innovation will become inevitable," said Ambani.

Addressing concerns around job losses, Ambani said AI will create new high-skill work opportunities rather than take away jobs.

Stating that the AI story has shifted from "who has the best model" to "who can build the strongest ecosystem for speed and scale of usage," he said Jio will build deep partnership ecosystem with Indian enterprises, start-ups, IITs, IISc, and research institutions.

"We will empower start-ups with affordable compute and co-development platforms," said Ambani.

Artificial general intelligence likely to unfold in five years

Our Bureau

Bengaluru



Demis Hassabis, CEO & Co-founder of Google DeepMind

Artificial general intelligence (AGI) could become one of the most momentous developments in human history, comparable to the advent of fire or electricity, and may unfold quickly within the next decade, said Demis Hassabis, Co-founder and CEO of Google DeepMind.

Speaking at the India AI Summit on Thursday, Hassabis said AGI, which he believes could emerge within the next five years, would have 10 times the impact of the Industrial Revolution but occur 10 times as fast.

Reflecting on the journey of AI, Hassabis said when DeepMind was founded in 2010, almost no one in the industry was working seriously on AI.

"It was just a dream. I spent my whole career working on AI since I believed it would be one of the most important and beneficial technologies ever invented. I always felt that AI would be the ultimate tool for accelerating scientific discovery and being a force multiplier for human ingenuity. We're already starting to see the beginnings of this with systems like AlphaFold that we built to solve the 50-year challenge of protein folding," he said.

Beyond biology, AI tools are being applied across material science, fusion research, physics, and mathematics, with nearly every scientific discipline poised to benefit.

INDIA AI PUSH

At the same time, Hassabis cautioned that the technology must be approached with humility. As foundational and general-purpose models are becoming more capable, the trajectory of their deployment remains

uncertain. "We don't know exactly how this technology will develop," he said, stressing the importance of understanding system capabilities and building robust guardrails and monitoring mechanisms.

During his visit to India ahead of the summit, Hassabis said he was impressed by the country's AI ecosystem. In Bengaluru, Google and DeepMind operate a research office focused on areas like efficient models, continual learning, and multilingual capabilities, work that feeds into global products.

He said India is poised to be a global AI powerhouse, citing partnerships, including a collaboration with the Reliance Jio group to bring Gemini foundation models to Indian users.

Looking ahead, Hassabis said the advent of AGI should be guided by a rigorous scientific approach, understanding what systems can do, building safeguards, and ensuring they serve societal goals. At the same time, he urged governments, scientists, artists, social scientists, and philosophers to shape their trajectory.

"This can't just be left to technologists," he said, adding that the ultimate objective must be to harness AI to advance science, improve medicine, and strengthen the human condition.

Solve at home, scale to the world: Rishad Premji

Avinash Nair

Ahmedabad

In rural Tamil Nadu, community health workers are carrying portable X-ray machines directly to people's homes. The scans are analysed instantly by artificial intelligence (AI) systems trained to detect signs of tuberculosis, enabling early screening and faster referrals — without patients having to travel long distances.

The pilot, supported by the Azim Premji Foundation, reflects what Wipro Executive Chairman Rishad Premji believes could become India's defining AI opportunity.

With nearly 2.7 million tuberculosis cases annually and a doctor-to-population ratio of roughly about 1:800 — far lower in rural pockets — AI can extend scarce medical expertise at scale.

"Solutions that work here in India — at scale, low cost, multilingual and resilient — can travel far beyond our

borders," Premji said while speaking at the AI Impact Summit, arguing that India's real contribution may lie not just in building AI, but in applying it to solve problems for the world.

For Premji, this marks a broader inflection point in the technology's evolution. "The conversation has fundamentally shifted from possibility to practicality, from experimentation to adoption and from pilots to scaled impact," he said, describing AI as a once-in-a-generation shift that will shape both India's economic trajectory and its ability to address large-scale societal challenges.

India, he argued, is uniquely positioned to become one of the world's most consequential environments for AI application. Systems here must operate across multiple languages, urban and rural settings, and varying levels of infrastructure and data quality.

That complexity, while demanding, makes successful



Rishad Premji, Wipro Executive Chairman

deployment globally relevant. The country's foundation is already visible. Around 650,000 professionals are currently working in AI-related roles, a figure expected to double by 2027.

Government initiatives aim to train 10 million young people in AI as expanding job-ready programmes. More than 4,000 deep-tech and AI start-ups are translating technological capabilities into real-world applications.

Use cases are emerging across sectors. Farmers in Karnataka, Maharashtra and Punjab are using AI systems

trained on satellite imagery and crop data to generate early pest alerts, reducing crop losses in some instances by nearly 25 per cent.

FRAGMENTED DATA

However, Premji cautioned that scaling AI within enterprises is complex. Legacy systems, fragmented data, regulatory requirements and siloed workflows make integration challenging.

"What enterprises need today is not a model that does everything, but models that do the right thing consistently," he said, advocating workflow-specific AI systems that are easier to govern and more reliable over time.

Ultimately, he stressed, successful adoption depends on people as much as technology — reskilling teams, redesigning roles and building trust in AI-assisted decision-making. "The dividing line will not be between humans and machines, but between those who adapt and those who hesitate," he added.

INCLUSIVE AI



TECH DRIVEN. India's strides in AI were showcased during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's speech at the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi on Thursday, which was dubbed live in 11 languages along with an AI-enabled sign language interpretation. The sign language interpretation was projected on a screen behind the PM at Bharat Mandapam, ensuring the speech was accessible to everyone [ANI](#)

AuraML launches India's 1st multimodal world simulation model for robotics

Our Bureau

Mumbai

Indian AI start-up AuraML unveiled AuraSim, billed as India's first multimodal world simulation model for robotics, built on Nvidia's Omniverse and Cosmos infrastructure. The announcement was made in New Delhi, coinciding with the India-AI Impact Summit 2026.

AuraSim allows developers to generate physics-ready, three-dimensional simulation environments from multiple input types, including text descriptions, 2D floor plans, video walk-throughs, depth maps and point clouds.

It is designed to reduce the time and cost of training autonomous robotic systems by creating high-fidelity digital twins before any hardware is deployed. The platform supports



simultaneous simulation of humanoid robots, autonomous mobile robots (AMRs), and stationary robotic arms operating within a shared virtual environment.

AuraML said its agentic automation pipeline can run thousands of scenario variations without human intervention, enabling rapid stress-testing of edge cases through simple text prompt modifications.

TRAINING PROGRAM

Alongside AuraSim, AuraML is launching the Global Physical AI & Robotics Cohort in

collaboration with Nvidia Inception, an eight-week mentorship-driven training program for robotics engineers, AI researchers, and developers, offered with limited seats.

"By launching the first multimodal world simulation model from India, powered by Nvidia's world-class simulation technology, we are providing a global toolset to accelerate the development of advanced robotics foundation models everywhere," said Ayush Sharma, Co-Founder of AuraML.

Tobias Halloran, Director of EMEA start-ups and Venture Capital at Nvidia, noted that India's AI start-up ecosystem is seeing strong momentum, with Nvidia providing founders access to accelerated computing and scalable AI infrastructure through programs like Nvidia Inception.

AI will drive FedEx's next 50 years, says CEO

Our Bureau

Hyderabad

FedEx Chief Executive Officer Rajesh Subramanian has said that the company's future differentiation will come from orchestrating the intelligence that governs modern commerce, driven by Artificial Intelligence.

"For the past 50 years, FedEx built the world's most reliable network for moving physical goods. Over the next 50 years, our differentiation will come from orchestrating the intelligence that governs modern commerce. That is our future," he said.

INDUSTRIAL SYSTEM

Addressing the AI Impact Summit 2026 in New Delhi on Thursday, he described AI as the "next industrial system" and detailed how the logistics major was tapping the two petabytes of daily

network data to predict, orchestrate, and optimise the entire supply chain.

"This is not just visibility into what happened, but intelligence about what will happen next. Identifying vulnerabilities and addressing them before they become disruptions is probably the most crucial element of supply chain resiliency," he said.

"Over the long term, we will power solutions allowing FedEx and our customers to anticipate disruption, to reroute flows, rebalance capacity, and prevent localised issues from becoming systemic failures," he said.

He said the company was scaling these capabilities responsibly. "We can embed our intelligence directly into customer workflows, helping businesses make sourcing, routing, inventory, and fulfilment decisions with near real-time supply chain insights," he said.

Microsoft's Brad Smith bats for massive AI infra push in Global South

Our Bureau

Hyderabad

Microsoft Vice Chair and President Brad Smith has called for a three-pronged strategy to promote the development of artificial intelligence in the Global South. Besides promoting a massive push for infrastructure in the form of data centres, compute and power, he wanted private and public investments and the development of skills and linguistic diversity, making AI as effective in every language as it is in English.

Addressing the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi on Thursday, he said that Microsoft is on track to invest \$50 billion by the end of the decade to bring AI to the Global South, with India among the largest beneficiaries.



Brad Smith, Microsoft Vice Chair and President

Stating that the future of artificial intelligence is a critical force that will either close or drastically widen the long-standing economic chasm between the Global North and South, he said that the current economic divide is fundamentally a result of a technology divide.

He pointed out to unequal access to general-purpose technologies like electricity as a historical precedent.

Terming the summit the first AI summit in the Global South, he cited the example of unequal distribution of infrastructure facilities, such as power, in the Global South and the Global North.

"We still live in a world where 700 million people lack access to electricity. AI will play a bigger role either in closing this economic divide or exacerbating it and making it even wider," he said.

INCREASE SKILLING

Calling for efforts to strengthen skilling, he said that Microsoft launched Microsoft Elevate to help people acquire digital skills that could open pathways to AI-driven opportunities. "We are also launching Microsoft Elevate for Educators to equip teachers with access to help their students learn how to use AI," he said.

When AI writes the code

Human judgment matters, as AI cannot empathise

M Muneer

TC S announced that automation and artificial intelligence would “reshape certain roles” within its technology teams. The phrasing was restrained; the implications were not. Within months, highly trained programmers found themselves competing not with lower-cost labour, but with systems capable of generating, debugging, and deploying code at speeds no human team could match. What appeared to be routine corporate communication marked a genuine inflection point in the nature of skilled work.

Large language models now draft reports, analyse data, design solutions, and synthesise knowledge across domains once treated as separate disciplines.

Here the idea of the Deep Generalist becomes consequential. A Deep Generalist is not a dilettante sampling multiple interests, but a professional grounded in one discipline while fluent across several others. The metaphor is T-shaped: depth in a core craft combined with breadth across adjacent domains. That breadth might include understanding how technology shapes behaviour, how incentives influence systems, how data informs strategy, and how regulation reframes opportunity. What is critical is disciplined fusion, not superficial dispersion.

AI gets smarter by feasting on huge data; humans grow sharper through curiosity and lived experience.

AI excels at discrete, rule-based tasks executed at scale. Humans maintain an edge in contextual synthesis and prioritization. The Deep Generalist uncovers connections hidden within functional silos — how customer sentiment shapes product design, how compensation frameworks skew technical decisions, and how regulatory changes ripple through operational risk. In doing so, they convert technical output into strategic coherence and organisational alignment.

ROLE OF JUDGMENT

As AI absorbs routine and repeatable work, human advantage shifts toward judgment. The essential questions are no longer merely technical feasibility, but purpose and consequence. Should a capability be deployed? For whom does it create value? What externalities accompany efficiency? Efficiency’s hidden



LIMITATION. Algorithms can only approximate sentiment

costs demand human judgement beyond algorithms and code.

Empathy is a very serious human contribution. Algorithms can approximate sentiment; they do not experience it. The ability to read hesitation in negotiation, recognise fatigue in teams, or sense resistance beneath silence remains distinctly human. Empathy underwrites trust, and trust underwrites coordination. In complex organisations, relational intelligence is infrastructural.

Agile enterprises are beginning to recognise this shift. Cross-functional teams, rotational assignments, and interdisciplinary projects aim to reduce silos and accelerate learning.

Cultivating such profiles requires cultural reform. Many organisations reward narrow optimisation, valuing technical depth over integrative ability. But in an AI world, surviving means building brains that wander sideways as well as straight up, so brushing elbows with other disciplines is the new job description.

Educational systems confront a parallel obligation. Combine technology, economics, and social impact. Quantitative literacy, systemic reasoning, ethical reflection, and precise communication are complementary competencies. Future professionals must learn to integrate analysis with narrative and innovation with responsibility.

As AI levels up, boring task-bots gobble routine jobs. Humans still win at “thinky stuff”: judgment, ethics, and turning skills into actual impact. The Deep Generalist? Part superhero, part Swiss army brain — anchored in smarts, stretching everywhere, turning chaos into consequences.

The writer is a Fortune-500 advisor, start-up investor and co-founder of the non-profit Medici Institute for Innovation



A NARAYANAMOORTHY

The recent announcement by the Tamil Nadu government to credit ₹5,000 into the bank accounts of 1.31 crore women has sent ripples through the State’s political and economic corridors. This disbursement, which includes three months of the Magalir Urimai Thogai and a newly minted “Summer Special” allowance of ₹2,000, marks a significant escalation in what economists call “competitive populism”.

While the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister has promised to double the monthly entitlement to ₹2,000 if returned to power, the Opposition AIADMK leader has countered with even more expansive promises, including free bus travel for all men and a matching monthly cash grant.

This bidding war mirrors a broader national trend where State-level fiscal prudence is increasingly traded away for direct benefit transfers to secure electoral mandates. As the State gears up for the 2026 Assembly elections, the sheer scale of these cash transfers raises fundamental questions about the sustainability of public finances and the long-term health of the developmental agenda.

VOLUME OF FREEBIES

Tamil Nadu has often been lauded for its focus on human capital, such as the mid-day meal scheme and subsidised essential commodities. However, the current shift towards direct cash transfers to a non-targeted population represents a departure from productive welfare towards a consumption-led drain on the exchequer.

The fiscal arithmetic of these promises is sobering. Currently, providing ₹1,000 per month to 1.31 crore women beneficiaries costs the exchequer approximately ₹15,720 crore annually. If this amount is doubled to ₹2,000, the annual burden will surge to over ₹31,000 crore, accounting for nearly 9 per cent of the State’s total revenue expenditure.

This massive allocation comes at a time when Tamil Nadu’s total outstanding debt is expected to reach ₹9,29,959 crore by March 31, 2026, with a revenue deficit estimated at ₹41,635 crore for the 2025-26 fiscal year.

The economic paradox is particularly sharp in a State like Tamil Nadu, where the multidimensional poverty level is estimated at just 2.2 per cent by NITI Aayog. In such a setting, a near-universal cash transfer scheme covering the majority of households cannot be justified.

When a State provides monetary support to 1.31 crore individuals, representing roughly 70 per cent of households, it ceases to be a safety net and becomes a State-funded electoral instrument, diluting resources for the truly poor. Furthermore, the debt-to-GSDP ratio is now pegged at 26.12 per cent, pushing the State closer



MOORTHY M

Freebies, and their many hazards

TAMIL NADU EXAMPLE. Freebies showered across a large swathe of voters squeeze out quality welfare for the really needy, and impact capex spending

to the fiscal limits mandated by transparency norms.

FREEBIES’ ELECTORAL VICTORY?

This freebie trend has become a national infection. Karnataka, Telangana, Maharashtra, Bihar, Andhra Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh too have entered this race to woo voters through direct benefit transfers (DBT).

However, evidence suggests that hefty freebies do not necessarily translate into electoral success. The 2024 defeat of the YSRCP in Andhra Pradesh, despite its massive “Navaratnalu” welfare basket and the lacklustre performance of the Congress in Karnataka during the 2024 Parliament elections despite implementing “Five Guarantees” costing ₹52,000 crore annually, prove that voters are increasingly discerning.

In Tamil Nadu, while revenue expenditure for 2025-26 is proposed at ₹3,73,204 crore, the capital outlay is only ₹57,231 crore, illustrating a stark imbalance between consumption and investment.

The hidden cost of this competitive populism is inevitably borne by the

The proliferation of sops for non-deserving populations fosters a dependency syndrome that undermines the dignity of labour

taxpayer. To fund these mounting welfare bills, the government has been forced to hike property taxes, electricity tariffs and registration fees over the last three years. This creates a regressive cycle where the State extracts money through essential utility hikes only to redistribute a portion of it as a political gift. Such a model erodes the purchasing power of the middle class and increases the cost of living.

When revenue expenditure outpaces revenue growth, the first casualty is capital outlay. This leads to decay in public infrastructure that will take decades and significantly higher costs to rectify. With committed expenditure (salaries, pensions and interest payments) already consuming 62 per cent of revenue receipts, the fiscal space for new development is rapidly shrinking.

MORAL HAZARD

Beyond the balance sheet, there is a looming cultural and sociological crisis. The proliferation of sops for non-deserving populations fosters a dependency syndrome that undermines the dignity of labour. If voters are conditioned to expect cash for their franchise, the very foundation of democratic accountability is weakened.

This freebie menace creates an environment where political parties are judged not on their vision, but on their bidding price. The taxpayer, whose interest payments alone now account

for 21 per cent of revenue receipts, will be the first to suffer when the fiscal cliff is finally reached and the State’s credit worthiness is downgraded.

No political party seems willing to stop this menace and there is every possibility of this competitive bidding intensifying. The only way to halt this slide is through institutional and judicial safeguards. Parties must be made to disclose how they propose to fund the freebies they promise.

The Supreme Court must take cognisance of this escalating crisis and frame stringent measures to stop political parties from providing unproductive and economically unsustainable freebies. Just as there are limits on individual candidate spending, there must be a fiscal cap on the promises made by parties. We are heading toward a scenario where the State’s primary function becomes debt servicing and subsidy distribution.

While protecting the vulnerable is an imperative, the current trajectory of indiscriminate cash transfers is a recipe for long-term disaster. Awareness among voters and proactive intervention by the judiciary are the only shields left. If we do not demand accountability now, future generations will be burdened by the mounting debt of today’s handouts.

The writer is an economist and former full-time Member (Official), Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices, New Delhi. Views are personal

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

February 20, 2006

Sales of eggs, chicken drop on bird flu reports

A drop in sales of eggs and chicken was reported in various parts of the country today following reports confirming avian influenza in poultry birds in Nandurbar in North Maharashtra. But broiler and layer-egg producers said it would take a few days more before the full impact of the development could be felt.

Experts, industry cry fowl over Govt flip-flop

After a few hours of brisk business on Sunday morning, Abdul sits close to an iron cage crammed with chicken in a licensed market in South Mumbai. . In the trade for over 20 years, he recalls 2003 when bird flu panic drove down chicken prices. It is a conspiracy to malign the poultry industry, he says. A black slate board hangs over his head with ₹54 chalked on it, indicating the day’s price on broiler chicken.

India, France to ink pact in defence, aerospace sectors

India and France are set to sign a host of agreements in a variety of fields including defence and aerospace during the three-day visit of the French President, Mr Jacques Chirac, which began on Sunday.

Spike in Venezuela crude output could stimulate US oil firms

Grant Smith
Nayla Razzouk

Venezuela can bolster oil production by 30-40 per cent this year, an increase of roughly 300,000 to 400,000 barrels a day, according to US Energy Secretary Chris Wright.

There’s “enormous” interest among companies seeking to enter the Latin American country, Wright said in an interview in Paris, where he is attending the ministerial meeting of the International Energy Agency. Such a boost would equate to about a third of global oil demand growth this year, he added. The Trump administration

recently issued licences allowing a handful of Western oil firms to operate in Venezuela. The US is trying to stimulate the nation’s oil industry and revive its economy following the capture of leader Nicolás Maduro earlier this year. The country’s oil production has fallen by about half since 2017, when Washington first imposed financial sanctions on the country.

ConocoPhillips has previously said it prefers to recoup the billions it’s owed by Venezuela rather than drilling new wells. Wright said that a range of “creative deals” could help resolve the situation, such as converting those debts into equity ownership.



HUGE INTEREST. In Venezuelan oil

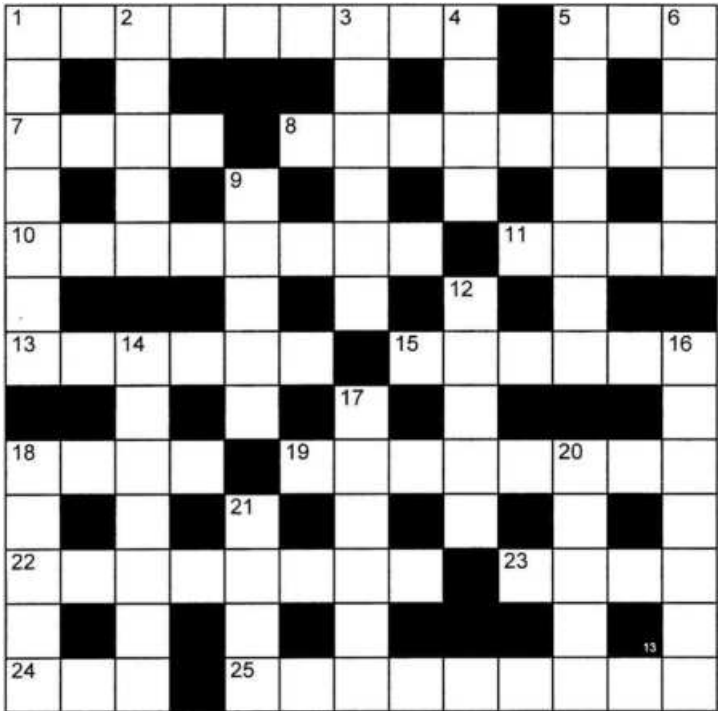
Oil prices are trading near a six-month high in London amid concern that President Trump could attack OPEC member Iran to contain

its nuclear programme. Prices have also been buoyed by an array of supply disruptions, including the impact of US-led sanctions on Iran and Russia.

Wright said that Trump’s pursuit of “energy dominance” — including growing domestic production, and rebuilding alliances in the Middle East and beyond — has freed US foreign policy from some of the concerns over energy prices it has been constrained by in recent decades.

A short-lived “blip” in oil prices during last year’s 12-day conflict between Israel and Iran — in which the US attacked Iranian nuclear facilities — is a good illustration of the changed dynamic, he added. BLOOMBERG

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2621



EASY

ACROSS

- To beg in the streets (Am) (9)
- Bushy head of hair (3)
- Skilfully (4)
- Glittered, was bright (8)
- A trend, drift (8)
- Grinding machine (4)
- Passing over violently and swiftly (6)
- Orison (6)
- Speak whiningly (4)
- Earlier, prior (8)
- See, understand (8)
- Thread, string, cord (4)
- Scarlet (3)
- Vision after the event (9)

DOWN

- Gesso (7)
- Man-made fibre (5)
- Describe, show (6)
- Nobleman (4)
- Soften, assuage (7)
- Foot-control (5)
- Deceptive movement in boxing (5)
- Small wood (5)
- Cognate, congenial (7)
- Hold in regard (7)
- Cowardly (6)
- Horse-dealer (5)
- Being in debt (5)
- Interlocking of gears (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- How American may beg for something to lift pot by (9)
- Small dog returns with a shock of hair (3)
- How Los Angeles gets by with skill (4)
- Glittered like snow-vehicle going round pleasure-ground (8)
- An inclination to deny cent in change (8)
- Grind it around and the crowd will move aimlessly (4)
- Thus doing gardening gets it in making a lot of money (6)
- Entreaty might take a year in Puerto Rico (6)
- Is unable to lose the apostrophe of hypocrisy (4)
- A former spiv turned roué perhaps (8)
- See that I have to creep around first (8)
- Row of yarn spun from good flax (4)
- The stop light was revolutionary (3)
- Ability to see what happened to things hid in such a way (9)

DOWN

- What goes to the wall may cover one’s hurt (7)
- Fabric only to be made at end of season (5)
- Minutely describe contents of nude pictures (6)
- A noble listener going to opening of Lords (4)
- Appease one if a milksop is around (7)
- Get bike moving quietly by breaking lead (5)
- A mock assault printer uses as a rule (5)
- Some trees the head gardener made over (5)
- Affinity with drink perhaps shown by editor (7)
- Broken sceptre one should treat with consideration (7)
- Cowardly cat starts to approach bird at Tower (6)
- Horse dealer took nothing from barrel-maker (5)
- It is due to go up and be victor inside (5)
- Become engaged, or married : he’s changing that (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2620

ACROSS 1. Praise 4. Hamper 9. Obligated 10. Sling 11. News 12. Fill 13. Kit 15. Drop 16. Stud 19. Ice 21. Foot 22. Acre 24. Alibi 25. Provide 26. Entity 27. Behead

DOWN 1. Prognosticate 2. Allowed 3. Sigh 5. Absolute 6. Prink 7. Right Reverend 8. Admit 14. Conflict 17. Decline 18. Poppy 20. Edict 23. Hope

QUICKLY.

US stocks stall as tech stocks slide



Wall Street's main indexes fell on Thursday, following a three-day winning streak for the S&P 500, as heavyweight technology stocks slipped, while Walmart shares gained after the retail giant's fourth quarter results. The retailer's new CEO, John Furner, kicked off his tenure with a conservative fiscal 2027 forecast as well as a \$30 billion buyback plan. Shares of the company rose 2.4 per cent. Other mega-cap and growth stocks, including Apple, Nvidia and Meta Platforms, traded lower after rising in the previous session. The Philadelphia SE Semiconductor index fell 1.6 per cent, while the broader S&P 500 technology index was down 0.9 per cent. REUTERS

JM Financial launches ₹1,500 crore pre-IPO AIF

Mumbai: JM Financial Asset Management on Thursday launched its first pre-IPO Alternative Investment Fund (AIF) under Category II, with a target corpus of ₹1,500 crore. The fund received approval from the SEBI and marks the firm's formal entry into the pre-IPO investment segment. The fund will target companies expected to go public within 18 months. It will be managed by Jaisinh Suchak, Managing Director, Alternative Investment Funds at JM Financial Asset Management. The launch is part of JM Financial's broader strategy to build out its AIF platform across credit, real estate and pre-IPO opportunities. OUR BUREAU

Brokers' body seeks 6-month pause on RBI's 100% cash collateral rule

MAJOR CONCERNS. ANMI flags liquidity risks, higher costs, uneven playing field for domestic firms

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The Association of National Exchanges Members of India (ANMI) has urged the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) to keep in abeyance a recent Reserve Bank of India amendment that tightens bank lending norms for capital market intermediaries engaged in proprietary trading. In a representation dated February 18, ANMI sought a six-month deferment of the RBI circular issued last week, which mandates banks to maintain 100 per cent cash collateral for bank guarantee (BG) facilities extended to capital market intermediaries (CMIs). The requirement has been raised from the



LIQUIDITY SQUEEZE. ANMI estimated that the proposed rule change by RBI would reduce overall collateral availability by about 2.5 per cent of total exchange collateral REUTERS

earlier 50 per cent and is scheduled to take effect from April 1. ANMI said the measure could have "unintended consequences" for market liquidity and depth. "The proposed changes may unintentionally constrain proprietary market makers and arbitrage desks, which are key providers of liquidity and price efficiency," the brokers' body said. Proprietary trading firms

play a critical role in market making, arbitrage and price discovery.

COLLATERAL PRESSURE A sharp increase in collateral requirements could curb access to bank financing for proprietary positions, widen bid-ask spreads and raise transaction costs for investors. The association also raised potential implications for foreign portfolio investor participation. Reduced liquidity and higher costs could make Indian markets less attractive, it said, adding that the move could create an uneven playing field.

"Foreign entities may continue to finance transactions through overseas banks or standby letters of credit, potentially shifting market share away from domestic

participants," ANMI said. It added that the capital market intermediary segment has historically shown near-zero non-performing assets. Around ₹1.2 lakh crore of bank guarantees are currently outstanding across exchanges, with no reported invocation even during periods of stress such as the 2008 global financial crisis or Covid.

The broker body estimated that the proposed rule change would reduce overall collateral availability by about ₹22,500 crore, or roughly 2.5 per cent of total exchange collateral. A six-month pause, it said, would allow market participants to submit feedback, conduct impact assessments and engage in constructive consultations with regulators. Emails to SEBI did not elicit a response.

Gaudium IVF raises ₹49.5 cr from anchors ahead of IPO

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Fertility services provider Gaudium IVF and Women Health Ltd on Thursday said it has raised ₹49.5 crore from anchor investors, ahead of the opening of its initial public offering (IPO).

According to a circular uploaded on BSE's website, the anchor investors are — MERU Investment Fund PCC-CELL, Sanshi Fund I, Hornbill Orchid India Fund and Carnelian India Multi Strategy Fund.

ANCHOR ALLOCATION Gaudium IVF has allocated 62,65,860 shares to these investors at ₹79 apiece. This aggregates the transaction size to ₹49.5 crore, per the circular.

The company's ₹165 crore IPO will open for subscription on February 20 and conclude on February 24. With this, Gaudium IVF will be-

come the first company in the fertility care sector to tap the public markets.

The price fixed price band of ₹75-79 per share values the company at ₹575 crore.

The proposed offering comprises a fresh issue of 1.14 crore equity shares and an offer-for-sale (OFS) of nearly 95 lakh equity shares by promoter Manika Khanna.

UTILITY OF FUNDS

Proceeds from the fresh issue are intended to establish 19 new IVF centres across India, along with payment of debt and for general corporate purposes.

Founded by Khanna, Gaudium IVF has established itself as a pioneer in assisted reproductive technologies in India.

The company operates through a hub-and-spoke model, with seven hubs and 28 spokes across multiple States, enabling it to reach a wide patient base.

NCC hits low on NHAI ban order, but recovers sharply

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Shares of NCC staged a sharp intra-day recovery on Thursday to close nearly unchanged after the infrastructure company disclosure that it and a subsidiary OB Infrastructure have been barred from bidding on National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) tenders for two years.

VOLATILE STOCK

The stock fell to ₹135 in early trade on the NSE, its lowest point in the past year, before recovering strongly to close at ₹150.35 on the NSE, up 0.39 per cent from

the previous close of ₹149.76.

Under the order, both entities are barred from participating in any NHAI tender, bid, or RFP, whether as concessionaire, contractor, EPC contractor, or consortium member, for a period of two years. The company contends the project faced delays due to NHAI's own lapses, and OBIL had won a favourable arbitration award in November 2024.

That award is currently being challenged by NHAI before the Delhi High Court. The market's closing verdict appeared to align with the company's own assessment of limited near-term damage.

Mid-cap funds attract investors as small-caps falter

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Growing uncertainty notwithstanding, investors are increasingly shifting their bets from small-cap to mid-cap funds.

The gross inflows into mid-cap funds rose by ₹1,139 crore in the last 12 months ended January to ₹94,043 crore, compared with ₹92,904 crore logged in small-cap funds.

After the recent meltdown in small-cap stocks, investors have shifted their focus to mid-cap mutual fund schemes.

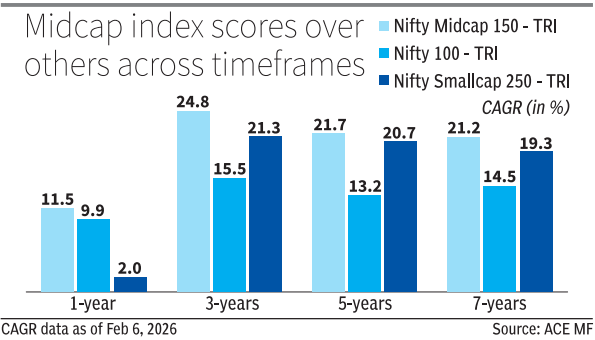
With strong inflows and better performance, the assets under management of

mid-cap funds have increased nearly 2.5 times to ₹4.61 lakh crore in December 2025 — up from ₹1.85 lakh crore in December 2022.

PERFORMANCE EDGE

The Nifty Midcap 150 has outperformed both the Nifty 100 and the Nifty Smallcap 250 indices across one-, three-, five-, and seven-year timeframes by fair margins.

Interestingly, most mid-cap MFs have beaten their benchmark indices. HDFC Mid-cap and Mahindra Manulife Mid Cap funds have delivered 27 per cent over three years, while mid-cap funds from Motilal Oswal MF and Kotak Mahindra MF delivered returns of 25 per



cent and 23 per cent in the same period.

Krishna Patwari, Founder & MD, Wealth Wisdom India, said mid-cap funds have attracted strong inflows over the past few years due to their superior return potential.

For instance, an eight-year

SIP in Mahindra Manulife Mid Cap Fund generated an extended internal rate of return of 22 per cent, outperforming its benchmark, with consistent rolling returns and relatively better risk-adjusted performance, he said.

Data from Franklin Templeton also show steady SIP

participation despite volatility, reinforcing investor commitment to long-term wealth creation. Investors must see this as a portfolio recalibration rather than excessive risk-taking. Mid-caps remain attractive for growth, but allocation discipline and a structured SIP approach are key, he added.

Shantanu Awasthi, Co-founder and CEO, Mavencor Wealth, said the flow into mid-cap funds has increased as both mid-cap indices and mutual fund schemes have performed well over the last six months, and people with a higher risk appetite are chasing higher returns. On the other hand, money had moved out of small-cap mutual fund schemes.

smallcase mulls global themes for domestic investors via Gift City

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

After opening international market investments to retail investors through Gift City, smallcase plans to launch analyst-recommended global theme-based ideas by May.

smallcase opened a facility for domestic investors to trade in US equities through Gift City-registered Global Access Provider Tickertape, a market information and tools platform.

The facility enables Indian residents to access the universe of over 7,000 stocks and ETFs listed on US markets in real time.

Vasanth Kamath, Founder & CEO, smallcase, said thanks to the updated regulatory framework, the process is now seamless, right from opening an account to LRS remittances, which are now fully digital with partner banks.



Vasanth Kamath, Founder & CEO, smallcase

Investors can select individual stocks and ETFs based on live prices displayed on Tickertape. Funds move from the investor's Indian savings account to the Gift City Global Access Provider account in dollars after conversion. From there, funds are transferred to the US brokerage. Investors do not need a bank account in Gift City.

Within a week of launch, smallcase has opened over 5,000 accounts, and transac-

tions are split equally between stocks and ETFs, said Kamath.

Investors have shown keen interest in themes unavailable in India, such as AI, biotech, space and deep tech, as well as commodity ETFs on copper, lithium and uranium, he added.

Investors can buy individual US stocks and ETFs, including fractional shares, starting at \$1.

By April-May, research analysts and advisors can create portfolio-based recommendations using US stocks and ETFs through smallcase, he said.

WEALTH OFFICE

Smallcase has also launched Wealth Office, a consolidated net-worth tracker app with an AI layer.

It integrates with the Account Aggregator framework and credit bureaus to automatically fetch mutual funds, equities, loans, NPS and vehicles.

BROKER'S CALL.

Mirae Asset Sharekhan

INDIGO PAINTS (BUY)

Target: ₹1,350
CMP: ₹965.25
Indigo Paints' consolidated revenues grew by 4.7 per cent y-o-y to ₹359 crore, driven by 3.5 per cent growth in the standalone business to ₹339 crore and 31.5 per cent growth in Apple Chemie (subsidiary) to ₹20 crore. Lower sales in Oct-25 (affected by early diwali and extended monsoon) affected revenues. Emulsions reported 3.4 per cent volume decline and 0.2 per cent value growth. Enamels and wood coatings posted volume/value growth of 20.2/18.9 per cent, respectively. Putty and cement paints grew by 2.1 per cent in volume and 5.5 per cent in value terms. Primers, distemper and others delivered 7.4/12.5 per cent volume/value growth, respectively. Gross margins were stable at 46.8 per cent supported by lower raw material prices and better mix, while OPM rose by 236 bps to 19 per cent, aided by lower A&P spends (at 5.6 per cent A&P spends were 260 bps lower y-o-y). A gradual recovery in the paints industry, widening presence across markets and capacity additions will aid revenue growth, while stable/lower raw material prices will support profitability in the near-medium term. We expect IPL to clock revenue and PAT CAGR of 9 per cent and 11 per cent, respectively, over FY25-FY28E. Stock trades at 30x/27x/24x its FY26E/FY27E/FY28E earnings, respectively. We maintain a Buy rating with a revised PT of ₹1,350. **Key risks:** Higher competitive pressure or increase in key input prices are key risks to our earnings estimates.

Motilal Oswal

TATA STEEL (BUY)

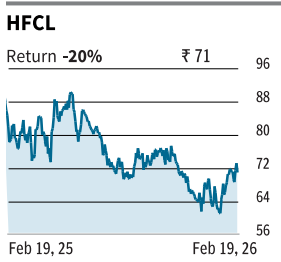
Target: ₹240
CMP: ₹205.45
We upgraded Tata Steel to Buy in Oct'25 at ₹177 and reiterated our positive stance on the name in our detailed steel thematic report in Jan'26. While the stock has performed well after our upgrade, we remain constructive on the stock on the back of a strong domestic demand outlook, safeguard duty-led price support, ongoing capacity expansions and a gradual turnaround in the EU business. India's steel demand is projected to grow by about 8-10 per cent over FY26-30, backed by a robust demand environment, policy support, and ongoing recovery in industry fundamentals. Tata Steel is aggressively expanding its capacity in India to capitalise on rising domestic demand, scaling from 26.5 mtpa in FY25 to 40 mtpa by FY31 over the medium term, with an annual capex commitment of ₹16,000 crore. Recently, Tata Steel commissioned 5 mtpa integrated capacity at Kalinganagar, increasing the plant's total capacity to 8 mtpa (₹270 billion investment), with phase-II expansion targeting 13 mtpa. Tata Steel is transitioning into green steelmaking in Europe, where it is converting Port Talbot (UK) to a 3 mtpa EAF from conventional BF route steelmaking. The company is also exploring a gas-based DRI + EAF route at IJmuiden (the Netherlands), subject to policy clarity. At CMP, Tata Steel is trading at 7.7x EV/EBITDA and 2.3x FY27E P/B. We maintain our Buy rating with an SoTP-based TP of ₹240 on Sep'27 estimate.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

HFCL (₹71.45): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau



The stock of HFCL has been in an uptrend for over three weeks. In early February, by rallying past the resistance at ₹69, the stock confirmed a double-bottom chart pattern. This indicates a potential bullish reversal in the trend. In addition, the price is above both the 21- and 50-day moving averages, and these averages have completed a bullish crossover.

So, although the stock fell 3.2 per cent on Thursday, the positive outlook remains intact, and the key support at ₹69 stays valid. Given the current chart setup, traders can buy HFCL

now at ₹71.45 and accumulate on a dip to ₹69. Place initial stop-loss at ₹67. When the stock rises to ₹76, revise the stop-loss to ₹72. On a rally to ₹78, alter the stop-loss to ₹75. Exit at ₹80.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

25410 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
25250	25150	25500	25750	Consider buying on a rally above 25500; stop-loss at 25400.

₹916 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
906	900	930	940	Downswing might extend; sell at 925 with stop-loss at 935.

₹1369 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1340	1290	1410	1450	Stock might stay sideways; refrain from fresh trades.

₹325 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
322	320	330	335	Go long on the stock at the current level with stop-loss at 320.

₹274 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
270	265	275	280	Buy the stock on breakout of 275; stop-loss can be at 270.

₹1410 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1400	1375	1420	1435	Stock shows bearish bias but there is support ahead; stay out.

₹1207 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1200	1190	1235	1250	Buy the stock when the price dips to 1200; stop-loss at 1180.

₹2680 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2665	2585	2750	2780	There is some uncertainty in intraday trend; stay out.

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 365.00 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WNN)	
ONGC	274.65	8.56	7.68	0.92	
Hindalco	905.65	2.03	12.66	1.13	
HDFC Life	733.15	0.84	83.55	0.68	
Dr Reddy's Lab	1282.30	0.27	13.38	0.67	
Kwality Walls	28.59	-0.14	0.00	0.02	
Wipro	211.21	-0.46	16.61	0.52	
Max Healthcare	1081.45	-0.78	74.13	0.69	
Coal India	416.15	-0.92	8.62	0.81	
Apollo Hosp	7592.50	-1.24	58.51	0.67	
TataConsumerProduct	1160.50	-1.31	78.04	0.65	
SBI Life	2043.00	-1.63	83.51	0.79	
Infosys	1370.50	-2.46	19.84	4.14	
Sun Pharma	1713.40	-2.55	37.53	1.56	
Cipla	1328.90	-2.58	23.68	0.64	
Asian Paints	2409.80	-3.10	58.90	0.94	
Adani Enter	2156.70	-3.11	17.61	0.48	
Tata Motors PV	375.70	-3.28	51.09	0.68	
Eicher Motors	7897.00	-3.40	40.43	0.94	
Bajaj Finserv	2033.20	-3.44	16.92	1.00	
NestleIndia	1278.50	-3.52	75.59	0.79	
Tech Mahindra	1479.30	-3.55	31.57	0.87	
TCS	2677.90	-3.81	20.20	2.36	
HCL Tech	1450.40	-3.89	23.90	1.32	
Bajaj Finance	1017.05	-3.93	34.54	2.33	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	258.60	-3.95	102.38	0.73	
Titan	4198.20	-4.56	78.20	1.49	
SJS	1228.40	-4.70	38.68	0.97	
NTPC	363.20	-5.41	14.18	1.48	
Trent Ltd.	4067.90	-5.81	89.27	0.78	
Grasim Ind	2864.30	-5.82	20.58	0.94	
PowerGrid Corp	294.65	-5.86	17.65	1.11	
Adani Ports	1513.30	-6.07	27.90	0.96	
Bajaj Auto	9729.00	-6.10	30.58	0.93	
Tata Steel	205.41	-6.56	28.11	1.46	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1054.70	-6.60	21.69	1.27	
Maruti Suzuki	14903.00	-7.51	31.38	1.69	
Int'l GlobeAvi	4815.10	-8.20	57.98	0.94	
Hind Unilever	2279.80	-8.60	53.26	1.74	
Eternal Ltd.	271.75	-8.82	1135.27	1.68	
UltraTech Cement	12688.00	-9.46	48.79	1.30	
Bharat Elec	435.35	-9.70	53.37	1.34	
L&T	4280.50	-11.69	31.03	4.33	
State Bank	1205.70	-12.01	12.86	4.31	
Axis Bank	1366.00	-12.02	15.94	3.35	
ITC	326.00	-13.63	19.73	2.71	
Kotak Bank	416.40	-16.05	22.03	2.64	
M&M	3431.80	-19.33	25.25	2.64	
Bharti Airtel	1988.60	-20.29	30.60	4.77	
ICICI Bank	1388.80	-30.39	17.54	8.55	
HDFC Bank	915.60	-38.53	18.11	12.07	
Reliance Ind	1409.50	-47.09	19.51	8.20	

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

HUL to invest ₹2,000 crore in high-growth categories

Mumbai: Hindustan Unilever said it would invest up to ₹2,000 crore over the next two years to expand production capacities in its high growth premium product categories, including Beauty & Wellbeing and Home Care liquids. The proposed investment is in line with its strategy of focusing on fewer, bigger bets and strengthening its presence in high-growth demand categories including premium skin care, hair care, personal care and home care liquids. The investment will be across multiple locations, it said. “The initiative is aimed at building a future-ready manufacturing network,” it said. “It reflects our strategic focus on scaling our brands and creating categories of the future to meet evolving consumer needs,” CEO and MD Priya Nair said in a statement. The expansion in manufacturing capacity is expected to boost supply chain efficiencies and agility to respond faster to customer demands, it added.

OUR BUREAU

Fillip for aerospace & defence, as TN signs ₹1,600-cr MoUs

WIN-WIN FOR ALL. Investments to create 1,900 jobs, said Industries Minister TRB Rajaa

Our Bureau
Chennai

In a push to the aerospace and defence sector in Tamil Nadu, four MoUs were signed by the Tamil Nadu Industrial Development Corporation Ltd, with various companies bringing in a cumulative investment of ₹1,600 crore and creating 1,900 jobs, said Industries Minister TRB Rajaa in a social media post.

INVESTMENT BREAK-UP PMI Engineering Exports signed an MoU to establish a precision aerospace manufacturing facility with an investment of ₹500 crore and a promise of 1,000 job opportunities. Catering to the civil aviation and defence sectors, the unit will manufacture



MAN OF THE HOUR. TRB Rajaa, TN Industries Minister, speaking at the Super Chennai conclave on Thursday BUJOY GHOSH

flight-critical components such as high-precision 5-axis CNC machining with micron-level tolerances, titanium alloys, inconel and nickel-based superalloys. Simvayu signed an MoU to establish a high-technology aviation training and simulation centre in Chennai at an investment of ₹600 crore and create 350 jobs on full

implementation. It has Level-D Full Flight Simulators for Airbus A320 and Boeing 737 MAX. It is a DGCA-compliant Approved Training Organisation providing aerospace certification with simulator engineering and R&D and drone simulation. Tychon Global Systems has signed an MoU to set up

an ammunition manufacturing facility in Thoothukudi at an investment of ₹500 crore. It is expected to generate 550 jobs.

It will carry out end-to-end production of 30 mm and 40 mm ammunition with precision machining, cart-ridge fabrication, fuze integration and ballistic testing.

Inbound Aerospace, an IIT-Madras-incubated start-up, signed an MoU to establish an advanced aerospace manufacturing facility at an investment of ₹100 crore for recoverable and reusable spacecraft with high-efficiency satellite solar panels, green thrusters for de-orbiting using advanced composites, avionics integration and clean-room assembly. It will provide 60 high-quality jobs in the first phase, said the Minister in the post.

We aim to break into top 10 UPI payments apps, says MobiKwik

bl.interview

Piyush Shukla
Mumbai

Payments sector major MobiKwik is aiming to break into the top 10 UPI payments apps from its current 12th spot, said CFO and Co-founder Upasana Taku. The payments app is already a leader in wallets space with 18-20 per cent market share, and is aiming to climb up in overall bill payments space, she said.

Edited excerpts:

The company posted a net profit in Q3 after multiple quarters of net loss. Will you remain profitable from here on? Absolutely. If you review our earlier data, till Q2FY25, we were EBITDA profitable and growing well. We took a hit for a few quarters due to disruption from a consumer credit cycle in unsecured lending. Even in Q2FY26, our EBITDA was negative ₹6 crore only, and this quarter we have posted 5 per cent EBITDA margin and 1.5 per cent PAT margin.

Our focus from hereon is on growing business. These profit numbers have been achieved due to operating leverage and, as we scale up, we expect to continue being profitable. Of course, every quarter we may not post 5 per cent profit margin, some quarters it may rise or fall, depending on business movement.

What is the guidance on gross merchandise value (GMV) growth?

We are a large player from a consumer payments perspective. Consumer payments has three categories — UPI, wallet and bill payments. We have been the market leader in wallet space for the last two years, with 18-20 per cent market share. At an industry level, wallet market has also grown 44 per cent from December 2024 to December 2025, according to the RBI's statistics. In bill



UPASANA TAKU
Co-founder, CFO, MobiKwik

payments, we are ranked seventh, as on December; in terms of consumers using our app to pay bills, we were number sixth in November. So, we intend to break into top five in this space as well.

UPI is of course the largest payment method in India. We have been among the top five fastest-growing apps every quarter for the last three quarters, and our rank has improved to from the 16th to the 12th spot in terms of consumer transactions on our app using UPI. We intend to break into the top 10 UPI apps. We are focusing on UPI growth as we are able to cross sell to users, whether it be wallet, bill payments or financial services. Overall, payments GMV has been growing for 12 quarters in a row and we intend to keep hitting new peak each quarter.

Should MDR be charged on person-to-merchant transactions on larger merchants?

It is extremely important. I know that UPI is looked as a service for public good, which is great, but there has to be some place at which money can be made. For example, we literally have thousands of merchants — online and offline — whose

monthly throughput is more than ₹1 crore. If your monthly sales is more than ₹1 crore and you are paying a fee on all other transactions like credit card, debit card, and net banking, then why should you not pay for UPI?

Because debit card fee is also coming from the same savings account. Large merchants can afford to pay for UPI transactions and they should be paying. Five to 10 years ago, UPI transactions' share in their daily overall transactions was much lower. So, they were paying for payment processing for other transactions.

Currently, large merchants are paying zero. Payment companies like us and banks are paying for it. There is a cost to maintaining that service. Cloud cost itself is high. Additional cost of product and tech development for managing the scale of payments is also extremely high. So, running these transaction services for zero is not sustainable. You can consider imposing MDR on merchants with monthly revenue of above ₹40 lakh to even ₹1 crore. Or for transaction value of ₹2,000 or ₹5,000 or more. You can still keep lower value transactions for free.

Your guidance on disbursement growth?

We don't have a specific guidance on growth rate, but you may look at the growth numbers over the last few quarters. In Q3FY25, we had done ₹400 crore of personal loan and ₹250-₹300 crore of buy now pay later loans (BNPL).

Now, BNPL as a product has been shut down by lenders and fintech players. So in Q3FY26, BNPL does not exist but we have done ₹900 crore of personal loan disbursements. We should be able to grow in double digit on an annual basis. In terms of lenders, we have four large NBFCs and six other smaller lenders for extending personal loans and some smaller secured products.

ePlane Company to use Nvidia solutions to build eVTOLs

Our Bureau
Chennai

The ePlane Company, an Electric Vertical Take-off and Landing (eVTOL) aircraft maker, has announced plans to build virtual versions of its e200x electric air taxis using Nvidia Omniverse libraries.

The company plans to create a 'Digital Twin' of its e200x series of eVTOL aircraft, which will engineer and simulate complex aero-



The ePlane Company's e200x taxi

dynamic interactions, sensor responses, and flight scenarios.

The collaborations will help validate extreme weather, sensor failures or

collision scenarios and enable teams to fly millions of kilometres virtually, training its algorithms for complex real-world scenarios before the aircraft even takes flight. “Collaborating with Nvidia allows us to blur the line between the digital and the physical. By validating our flight operations suite in Nvidia Omniverse, we are effectively pushing the limits of the aircraft thousands of times in simulation so that we never have to in reality,”

said Satya Chakravarthy, Founder & CTO, The ePlane Company.

“Nvidia is accelerating India's start-up momentum by giving founders direct access to accelerated computing, scalable AI infrastructure, and programmes like Nvidia Inception for start-ups and the Nvidia VC Alliance — helping start-ups scale faster and build for global markets,” Tobias Halloran, Director of EMEA Startups and Venture Capital at Nvidia.

Navi charts next phase with credit-on-UPI push, secured lending tilt

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Navi is sharpening its focus on product depth and institutional scale, MD & CEO Rajiv Naresh told *businessline*, outlining a forward roadmap across payments, lending and asset management.

“The second inflection point of our journey is UPI,” Naresh said, pointing to the rise of Navi UPI. The app has gained 3.2 per cent market share by transaction volume and 1.3 per cent by value within two years, emerging as the fourth-largest player in the ecosystem.

“One could have argued that there's no space for a fourth player to emerge and take almost 4 per cent market share in 18 months,” he said. “But consumers tell us that they feel our experience is faster and more seamless.”

Naresh added that the next phase will centre on embedding credit into the payments stack. “In my mind, there will be no more efficient engine to deliver credit to the masses than credit on UPI,” he said, underscoring the company's belief in converging payments and lending rails.

LENDING AND AMC

“Lending is our core,” Naresh said, noting that the company has recalibrated its loan book towards lower-risk assets. The mix is now roughly 80 per cent un-



Rajiv Naresh, MD & CEO, Navi

cured and 20 per cent secured, with secured assets expected to grow further in absolute terms.

“The quality of our book is in a constant upward trajectory,” he said, signalling tighter underwriting and stronger governance frameworks amid a more stringent regulatory environment.

On asset management, Naresh said Navi Mutual Fund will build on its passive-first foundation while broadening its product suite.

Looking ahead, the ambition is clear. “Over the next three years, we aim to be amongst the fastest-growing AMCs led by product innovation, digital expansion in B30 cities and a commitment to giving retail investors the same sophisticated tools once reserved for institutions.”

Together, the strategy signals a pivot from rapid expansion to disciplined scale — with credit-on-UPI, secured lending and retail-focused investing forming the pillars of Navi's next growth cycle.

Amid buoyant domestic focus, Montra Electric explores export markets for e-3W

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Montra Electric, the electric vehicle (EV) manufacturing arm of the Murugappa Group, is exploring exports of its electric three-wheelers (E3W) to Nepal, Sri Lanka and Tanzania.

“We are seeding these markets with a few units,” said Deependra Sharma, CEO, 3EW, Montra Electric, told *businessline*. “Unlike India, power availability could pose challenges in these geographies. We are just testing the markets at this stage,” he added.

The export push comes amid rapid maturation of the domestic electric three-wheeler market. Sharma said the current year has been particularly significant for the company, which launched a refreshed version of its electric passenger E3W and entered the cargo segment.

The company also introduced fast-charging options in select markets such as Delhi and Bengaluru, enabling vehicles to be charged in under 30 minutes. This is relevant in metro cities, where home charging infra-



Deependra Sharma, CEO, 3EW, Montra Electric BUJOY GHOSH

structure is limited and operators cannot afford extended vehicle downtime, he said.

On the manufacturing front, Montra Electric tested production readiness by crossing the 1,000-unit mark in a single month at its plant in Chennai. While this was a capacity test rather than sustained output, Sharma said it demonstrated the plant's scalability as demand rises.

TREND OF E-3WS

Over the past two years, the E3W market has evolved significantly. “Earlier, adoption was driven largely by early experimenters. Today, E3Ws have the highest EV penetration among all vehicle segments,” Sharma said.

COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LTD.
CIAL/FS/PR/2026-01/TTL (Retender)-01 20.02.2026
TENDER NOTICE
Design, Supply, Testing, Commissioning and Handing over of Turntable Ladder at Cochin International Airport Limited.

Cost of tender document	EMD	Estimated Cost for Procurement	Completion period
Rs. 10,000/-	Rs. 34,00,000/-	Rs.1,350 Lakhs excluding taxes	16 months

Interested firms may submit their application on or before **27th February 2026**. For eligibility criteria and other details, visit our website www.cial.aero.

TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)
The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 2nd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India (Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567
NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)
The Tata Power Company Limited invites tender from eligible vendors for the following tender package (Two-part Bidding) in Mumbai.
1) OLA for Azure Managed Services for a period of 3 Years. (Package Reference 4100060736)
2) OLA for 3 Years for QA-QC Services for MIT Stores. (Package Reference 4100060714)
For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Interested bidders to submit Tender Fee, Authorization Letter along with Complete Bid Document by **15:00 Hrs, Thursday, 12th March 2026**. Also, all future corrigendum's (if any), to the above tender will be informed on website <https://www.tatapower.com> only.

CIAL COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LTD.
CIAL/COMM/DC/02 20/02/2026
TENDER NOTICE
Online Item rate E-tenders are invited from reputed agencies for the work mentioned below at Cochin International Airport.

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Estimate Amount	EMD	Completion Period
1	SITC of Data Center Infrastructure at CIAL.	Rs. 3.75 Crore + GST	Rs. 7.50 Lakh	08 Months

Interested firms may register themselves on the online E-Tendering portal <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> and then download the Tender documents. For eligibility criteria and other details, visit our website www.cial.aero

Sd/-, **MANAGING DIRECTOR**

CMTI CENTRAL MANUFACTURING TECHNOLOGY INSTITUTE
(An Autonomous R&D Institute under the Ministry of Heavy Industries, Govt. of India) Tumakuru Road, Bengaluru - 560022
Advt No.: CMTI/PUR/04/2025-26 Advt.Dt.:20-02-2026
NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER
Tenders are invited for in "Two Cover System" for:

S.N	Supply, Installation & Commissioning of	EMD(₹)
1.	Supply, Installation and commissioning of Electrically Operated Pit Type Furnace	80,000/-
2.	Supply, Installation, Testing and commissioning of CNC Turning Machine	NIL
3.	Laser Sheet Metal Cutting Machine	NIL

Reputed Manufacturer/Authorised Representatives may participate through GeM Portal. The tender details, eligibility criteria etc., can be viewed from <https://cmti.res.in/all-tender/>

Ekki Homa launches sewage pumps for Indian market

The Hindu Bureau
Coimbatore

Ekki Homa, a joint venture of the Coimbatore-based Ekki Group and Germany's Homa Pumpenfabrik, has launched the Linus range of sewage pumps in the Indian market.

Kanishka Arumugam, Co-chief Executive Officer of Ekki Homa, said on Thursday that the Linus range of pumps was developed for the Indian market and tested in 100 locations. In the last two years, a supply chain that would meet the German standards was developed to make the sewage pumps.

About 75 dealers would be appointed in three

years across the country, and service centres would be set up to cater to the sewage pump segment. The eight-year-old joint venture's production capacity will make pumps to cater primarily to the Indian market of German technology and also supply pumps to Germany.

OIL PALM INDIA LIMITED
Regd. Office: A/13/30, Kottayam South P.O., Kottayam - 686 013.
Phone: 0471-2227104
Fax: 0471-2227105
Website: www.oilpalmindia.com
Email: info@oilpalmindia.com
E - Tender Notice
0P/SEC/PUR/9/2025-26/4758 16-02-2026
Competitive E Tenders are invited for the supply of 105MT Magnesium Sulphate. For details refer company's web site or www.etenders.kerala.gov.in
South India Editions of Business Line.
(E Tender ID: 2026_OPLI_836556_1)
Last date 28-02-2026 6.55 PM.
Sd/-
Secretary & Sr.Manager

E-Auction Sale
Padmashri Dr. Vithalrao Vikhe Patil S.S.K. Ltd.
Pravaranganar, Tal. Rahata, Dist. Ahilyanagar (M.S.) - 413 712
Phone 02422-252301 to 04, E-mail: sai.eauctioneer@gmail.com
Mob.No.8551821111
ONLINE AUCTION CONDUCTED BY
Hari Ramechandra E-Auctioneers Pvt. Ltd.
Office Address:- Shop No-49, Aditya Shagun Mall, NDA Poshan Road, Bavdhan Khurd, Pune-411021, Website: www.hrauctioneers.com, E-mail: hri.auctioneers@gmail.com
The Auction will be held on 09-03-2026 at 11.00 AM onward on www.hrauctioneers.com to sale sugar mill tandum cane carrier to all mill (7500 TCD Ulka make 42" x 84" & Bakauwolf make 36" x 78") by E-Auction. The following machinery on "As is where is basis"
1. Cane Carrier to All milling units
2. 42" x 84" Ulka make mill with electric drive- 1 Nos.
3. 36" x 78" Bakauwolf make with Electric drive- 4 Nos.
With details given in catalogue.

Material inspection at sugar factory site 21/02/2026 between 9.00 am To 5.00 Pm	between 9.00 am To 5.00 Pm
All documents & participation fees submitted at sugar factory Account Dept. by RTGS/ NEFT/DD Last date - 07/03/2026 at 5.00 Pm	Last date - 07/03/2026 at 5.00 Pm
Under any circumstances, Bidder document & participation fee will not be accepted after Dt.07/03/2026	
Detail machinery list, Bidder form, Participation fee Term & Conditions will get from E-Auctioneer website	
Website: www.hrauctioneers.com , Mob.no.9850753434, 8149187647	

M.M.Konapur Managing Director
Sopan V.Shirsath Patil Vice Chairman
Dr.Sujay R.Vikhe Patil M.S.M.Ch(Neuro Surgery) Chairman

TATA POWER RENEWABLE ENERGY
Communication address: 78, Electronic City Phase-1, Hosur road, Bangalore - 560100.
Registered office: Tata Power Corporate office, 34, Sant Tukaram Road, Carnac Bunder, Mumbai-400009
CIN: U40108MH2007PLC168314, Tel 91 22 8717 1000
NOTICE INVITING VENDORS FOR EMPANELMENT
Tata Power Renewable Energy Ltd. (TPREL) Invites for submission of registrations from interested and eligible Vendors for the following Works required for its Renewable Projects across India.

S.No.	Solar Project Services	S.No.	Wind Project Services
1	MMS Pile Foundation Works	1	WTG Foundation Works
2	Main Control Room Buildings	2	Main Control Room Buildings
3	Equipment Foundation Works (ICR/IDT/BESS)	3	Balance of Plant including ROW
4	Approach, Internal and Peripheral Road Works	4	33kV Transmission line services contracts
5	Plant Drainage Works	5	Transmission Line
6	Boundary Fencing Works	6	Switchyard Works
7	Switchyard Works	7	EPC/Turnkey works for complete wind projects including all approvals but excluding WTG and Land
8	Transmission Line		
9	Earthing Works		
10	AC Side Electrical Works		
11	DC Side Electrical Works & Earthing works		
12	EPC/Turnkey Works for complete Solar package including all approvals but excluding all major supply		

Interested bidders for above service works are requested to submit required credentials as per Pre-Qualification (PQ) Criteria set for individual services before **15:00 Hrs. Sunday, 15th March 2026**.
For detailed Notice Inviting Vendors for Empanelment, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. For detailed Service-wise PQs and requisite documents to be submitted, please visit Tender section on website, **RFQ Reference no. 4100060940**.
Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said Notice will be published on Tender section of above website (**Tata Power > Business Associates > Tender Documents**) only.

QUICKLY.

Gold advances as markets weigh Fed policy path



Gold prices extended gains on Thursday after rising more than 2 per cent in the previous session, as lingering tensions between the US and Iran prompted a flight to safety, while investors evaluated the Fed's monetary policy path. Spot gold rose 0.2 per cent to \$4,989.09 per ounce by 1227 GMT. US gold futures for April delivery held steady at \$5,008.60. REUTERS

Copper slips on subdued demand, high inventories

London: Copper fell as rising inventories and subdued demand due to the holiday in top metals consumer China weighed on prices. Benchmark three-month copper on the London Metal Exchange edged down 0.7 per cent to \$12,816 a tonne as of 1010 GMT. Zinc fell 0.3 per cent to \$3,342.50; aluminium shed 0.7 per cent to \$3,067. REUTERS

Crude oil prices gain on US-Iran conflict



London: Crude oil prices rose driven by increasing concerns over a potential military conflict between the US and Iran as both countries stepped up military activity. Brent futures were up 91 cents at \$71.26 a barrel by 1058 GMT, while US WTI crude gained 90 cents to \$66.09. REUTERS

FCI to supply 2 lakh tonnes of rice to World Food Programme

TERMS AND CONDITIONS. The MoU is valid till 2031; prices will be revised annually on mutual consent

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Food Corporation of India (FCI) and the World Food Programme (WFP) have signed an agreement for the supply of rice to support global hunger relief efforts. Under the arrangement, FCI will supply 2 lakh tonnes of rice (up to 25 per cent broken) to WFP at ₹2,800 per quintal. Both agencies have entered into a memorandum of understanding (MoU), valid until 2031, to support humanitarian operations aimed at combating hunger worldwide, the Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution said in a statement on Thursday.



AIDING FOOD SECURITY. The current price of ₹2,800/quintal will remain effective until March 31

While the current price of ₹2,800 per quintal will remain effective until March 31, 2026, the rate will be revised annually based on mutual agreement. Union Food Secretary Sanjeev Chopra said the partnership reflects India's commitment to global food security. "Through our partnership

with WFP, we are exporting hope, nutrition and dignity to those facing hunger. This agreement showcases India's resolve to ensure no one goes hungry," he said.

'KEY MILESTONE' Deputy Executive Director Carl Skau described the pact as a key milestone in the fight against global hunger. "India's support will help WFP reach vulnerable populations with nutritious food more effectively over the next five years," he said. The partnership reinforces India's role in addressing humanitarian food needs and strengthens co-operation with WFP in tackling malnutrition and food insecurity worldwide.

Indian cardamom gains flavour on global supply disruptions

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi



Indian cardamom exporters are pinning their hopes on the 2026 export season, which is witnessing an unprecedented surge. Shipments are projected to touch around 14,000 tonnes, nearly double the historical average. The sharp upswing is largely attributed to a 50 per cent production drop in Guatemala, creating a significant supply gap in the global market.

EXPORTS SURGE Riding on strong spot bookings at the recently concluded Gulfood expo, Indian exporters have regained dominant market share in Iran ahead of Nowruz and across West Asia, including Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and the UAE, in the run-up to Ramadan, said SKM Dhanavanthan, a cardamom exporter based in Bodinayakanur.

The Guatemalan crop failure has created an opportunity for Indian cardamom to scale new highs in overseas markets, with exports currently driving the trade

created an opportunity for Indian cardamom to scale new highs in overseas markets, with exports currently driving the trade.

Export momentum is expected to continue over the next few months as buyers scramble for premium exportable grades, said SB Prabhakar, a planter from Idukki.

Prices are holding steady around ₹2,450 per kg on the back of strong overseas demand. The picking season is nearing its end, with light harvests expected through March-April. The 2025-26 crop is estimated at 32,000-35,000 tonnes, supported by favourable weather and improved farm management. Domestic demand is also expected to pick up ahead of Holi. With the La Nina conditions prevailing, spring showers expected between late February and March could support the next crop cycle.

GOLDEN WINDOW PC Punnoose, General Manager of KCPMC Ltd, said the Guatemalan crop failure had

Maize's share nears 50% in domestic ethanol output

Our Bureau
Bangaluru

The role of maize in India's ethanol blending programme has strengthened considerably during the Ethanol Supply Year (ESY) 2024-25 (November-October), reflecting a clear shift in feedstock dynamics. Maize emerged as the dominant raw material, accounting for nearly half, approximately 48 per cent, of total ethanol production during the November-October cycle, per latest data shared by the All India Distillers Association (AIDA), a trade body of ethanol, bio-energy and potable alcohol producers. This marks a notable increase from the 42.6 per cent share recorded in the previous supply year.

In recent years, maize has overtaken traditional sugarcane-based feedstocks to become the primary source of raw material for the ethanol production process in the country. "Out of the total ethanol allocated for the current cycle, maize-based production has seen unprecedented growth, supported by favourable government policies and increased procurement prices (₹71.86 per litre for maize-based ethanol)," AIDA said in a statement



provide a balanced feedstock mix, it said. India's ethanol supply programme continues to demonstrate strong momentum, with cumulative supplies reaching approximately 1,039 crore litres against a contracted volume of 1,163 crore litres, reflecting an overall 89 per cent fulfilment. Total grain-based feed stocks, including maize and rice, accounted for 718 crore litres, contributing to nearly 69 per cent of the ethanol supplied, up from 59 per cent in the previous year. Sugarcane based feed stocks accounted for 321 crore litres or 31 per cent of the total volumes during 2024-25, down from 41 per cent in the previous year. Vijendra Singh, President, AIDA, said, "The increasing contribution of maize and other grain-based feedstocks is strengthening supply stability while reducing dependence on any single source. With maize now contributing nearly 50 per cent of our feedstock, we have successfully decoupled ethanol production from the sugar cycle. This not only ensures a year-round supply of

biofuel but also provides a massive boost to maize farmers across the country." "AIDA has urged the government for policy beyond E20 and further explore ethanol-diesel and isobutanol blending to utilise the massive surplus capacity we have built," he added. **FOREX SAVINGS** The ethanol industry has a cumulative capacity of around 2,000 crore litres, with over 380 dedicated distilleries operational and another 33 in the pipeline. India has already achieved a 20 per cent blending target in 2025. To date, the EBP programme has saved over ₹1,55,000 crore in foreign exchange and significantly reduced CO₂ emissions, AIDA said.

Water levels in major reservoirs drop below 75% of capacity across all regions

Our Bureau
Chennai



Storage in the country's 166 major reservoirs dropped this week to 61.65 per cent of the capacity, with the level dropping below 75 per cent in all five regions this week. Data from the Central Water Commission (CWC) showed that the storage in key reservoirs was 113.160 billion cubic metres (BCM) against the 183.565 BCM capacity. It was 11.5 percentage points higher than last year and 25 percentage points more than normal (the last 10 years). According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the country received 56 per cent deficient rain from the beginning of the year to February 18, with central India receiving 85 per cent deficient precipitation. Data received from 727

districts showed that 80 per cent of the country received deficient or no rainfall so far this year. The CWC's weekly bulletin said four reservoirs are brimming still, but the number of reservoirs with over 80 per cent storage is down to 20 per cent. In over 22 per cent of the reservoirs, the level was below 50 per cent. Storage in the southern region's 47 reservoirs continued to be a tad lower than

last year at 53.12 per cent of the 55.288 BCM at 29.371 BCM. In Andhra Pradesh, the storage was 66.5 per cent, while it Tamil Nadu, it was 59 per cent. In Kerala, Karnataka and Telangana, the level was 55 per cent, 49 per cent and 44 per cent, respectively. In the western zone, the 53 reservoirs were filled to 73 per cent of the 38.094 BCM at 27.684 BCM. Goa's lone reservoir was filled to 75 per cent, while the level in Maharashtra and Gujarat was 73 per cent each. **ASSAM PRECARIOUS** In the 28 reservoirs of the central zone, the level was 66 per cent of the 48.588 BCM capacity at 31.868 BCM. Storage in Chhattisgarh was nearly 79 per cent, but it was lower than 60 per cent in Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand. In Madhya Pra-

desh, the level was 67 per cent. The level in 11 reservoirs in the northern region was 11.330 BCM or 57 per cent of the 19.836 BCM capacity. In Punjab and Rajasthan, storage was above 65 per cent, while in Himachal Pradesh, it was 50 per cent. In the eastern region, storage in the 27 reservoirs was 59 per cent of the 21.759 BCM capacity at 11.33 BCM. The level in Meghalaya's lone reservoir was 96 per cent, while it slipped below 25 per cent in Assam was 26 per cent and below 40 per cent in West Bengal. Storage in Odisha was 63 per cent and in Jharkhand and Tripura above 60 per cent. A low-pressure area in the Bay of Bengal may help the storage improve in South India, though the overall capacity will likely decline further as the country heads towards summer.

SHEARING SEASON



FIBRE FOCUS. Farmers shear wool from sheep using traditional hand shears in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh. Wool production in the State rose to 8.37 lakh kg in 2025, up from 8.28 lakh kg in 2024. The Integrated Wool Development Programme launched by the Ministry of Textiles, focussing on quality improvement and market linkages, is helping to increase the fibre's production in the country. PH

Concerns linger over S-W Monsoon outlook as APCC issues El Nino watch

Srikrishnan PC
Chennai

The APEC Climate Center's (APCC) has issued an "El Nino" watch, which means the drought-bearing weather could emerge in the upcoming seasons. Above-normal temperatures are most likely across much of the globe, except for some parts of the southern tropical ocean, according to the report. In particular, it said chances are more for above normal temperatures in India, besides western Europe, Central Asia, Russia, Australia, eastern North America and southern South America. APCC said there was an increased probability for below normal precipitation in India, Central America and

northern South America. A tendency for below normal precipitation is predicted for tropical Atlantic and southern Australia. For India, this could result in the South-West monsoon being affected similarly to 2023. In 2023, El Nino lead to deficient monsoon and drought in at least 25 per cent of the country. In particular, it affected pulses, coarse cereals and paddy production, which led to India curbing rice exports. El Nino typically leads to drought and prolonged dry spells in Asia, particularly India, and parts of Africa. **SEASONAL OUTLOOK** During March-May, above-normal precipitation is expected over the tropical North Pacific, the subtropical south-western Pacific,

and the eastern equatorial Pacific. Below-normal precipitation is predicted for the Maritime Continent, the off-equatorial South Pacific, and the north-western Pacific. During June-August 2026, above-normal precipitation is expected over the equatorial and western North Pacific. Between March and May, there is a strong probability of above-normal temperatures across the north-eastern Atlantic, the Mediterranean, central Africa, West Asia, the equatorial Indian Ocean, eastern East Asia and the North Pacific, the tropical North Pacific and the southwest Pacific, the Caribbean, Mexico, the subtropical North Atlantic, the south-eastern South Pacific and central South America.

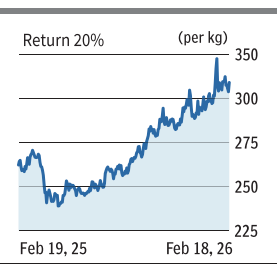
Buy zinc futures at ₹322 with a stop-loss at ₹314

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

For about two weeks now, zinc futures (currently trading at ₹324/kg) have been in a sideways crawl. That is, since the beginning of this month, they have been oscillating between ₹318 and ₹332.

COMMODITY CALL.

On Wednesday, the contract gained nearly 2 per cent after rebounding from the lower boundary of the range, i.e., ₹318. A trendline coincides with this base, making it a strong support. Going ahead, there is a chance for zinc futures to rally past the upper boundary of the range at ₹332 and attempt to move towards



₹340 and ₹350. On the other hand, if the bears gather more strength and lead to a breach of the support at ₹318, the near-term outlook will turn bearish. Notable support below ₹318 is at ₹300, although ₹312 is a minor one. **TRADE STRATEGY** Buy zinc futures at ₹322 and place a stop-loss at ₹314. When the contract reaches ₹332, trail the stop-loss to ₹322. Book profits at ₹340.

Meghalaya showcases organic farming capability at global fair in Germany

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Meghalaya made its debut at BIOFACH 2026, a trade fair for organic food and agriculture, in Nuremberg, Germany, positioning the State as an emerging, institution-backed organic sourcing destination from North-East India. A statement said BIOFACH 2026 provided a strategic global platform for Meghalaya to present its integrated organic ecosystem, spanning certification systems, farmer collectivisation, branding and export-oriented value chains. Vijay Kumar D, Commissioner and Secretary to the Meghalaya government and Chairman of MEGNOLIA (Meghalaya Natural and Or-

At BIOFACH 2026, Meghalaya showcased certified organic ginger, turmeric and sticky rice

ganic Farming Society for Livelihood and Innovation in Agriculture), outlined the State's organic development roadmap, highlighting its community-driven model anchored in institutional strength, ecological sustainability and market integration. **STATE'S STRATEGY** The presentation emphasised how farmer collectives, supported by enabling policy frameworks and certification systems, are progressively aligning with global organic standards, traceability

requirements, and sustainability benchmarks. Farmer representatives from the State attended the trade fair. At BIOFACH 2026, Meghalaya marked a strong presence through a dedicated pavilion showcasing certified organic ginger, turmeric, and sticky rice. The State's organic narrative was further amplified through partners, including Mother India, Plantrich, HIFED and IFOAM, where its pineapples were showcased in higher value-added forms, such as pineapple concentrate, purée and freeze-dried products. This reflected the State's steady shift from primary commodities to diversified, export-ready organic products aligned with evolving global demand, the statement added.



FEDERATION OF INDIAN
EXPORT ORGANISATIONS
Set up by Ministry of Commerce, Government of India

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Processed Foods & Organic Products – Expanded export avenues for India's agri-value chain.

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S C Ralhan
President, FIEO



Ravikant Kapur
Vice President, FIEO



Dr. Ajay Sahai
Director General & CEO, FIEO

FEDERATION OF INDIAN EXPORT ORGANISATIONS

(Set up by Ministry of Commerce, Government of India)

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QUICKLY.
Adobe to offer Photoshop, Acrobat apps for free



New Delhi: Global tech leader Adobe on Thursday announced a strategic investment to accelerate AI-driven creativity and productivity for India's next generation of talent at the India AI Impact Summit. The company said it is enabling the next generation to be ready for AI-first careers, by putting its applications such as Firefly, Photoshop and Acrobat, into the hands of students for free, via accredited higher education institutions across India. "In partnership with the government, Adobe will make its AI-first offer, along with our industry-endorsed curriculum, free for the 15,000 schools and 500 colleges that will have Content Creator Labs," it added. The toolkit provides access to Adobe's creativity and productivity software along with curriculum, training and credentials. **OUR BUREAU**

Bangladesh bars SpiceJet from using its airspace

New Delhi: Bangladesh has barred SpiceJet from using its airspace as the budget carrier is yet to repay pending dues, according to sources. With the Bangladesh airspace not being available, the airline is taking longer routes for some of its flights from Kolkata, including to Guwahati. A SpiceJet spokesperson said the airline was in regular dialogue with the authorities on operational and procedural matters, including navigation-related charges. "These are routine industry issues and we are working constructively towards an early resolution. Our flight operations remain unaffected, and we continue to operate our scheduled services in line with regulatory requirements," the spokesperson said. **¶¶**

DGCA to evaluate IndiGo rostering system ahead of summer schedule

CLOSE WATCH. Regulator to review crew planning, KPIs and pilot strength as airline seeks higher slot allocation

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

India's aviation regulator will conduct dry runs of IndiGo's pilot rostering software to assess whether the airline is ready to handle a higher number of domestic flights during the upcoming summer season.

The move comes as the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) prepares the summer schedule of flight operations for domestic airlines.

According to sources, IndiGo has sought permission to operate between (approximately) 2,100 and 2,300 domestic flights during the summer schedule.

Presently, IndiGo has capped its domestic operations at approximately



FLIGHT PLANS. IndiGo has sought permission to operate between 2,100 and 2,300 domestic flights as part of its summer schedule, say sources

1,850-1,900 flights per day until March 31, 2026.

Speaking to *businessline*, industry insiders said that such capacity management is intended to maintain schedule reliability, while the airline adapts to the full implementation of the flight duty time limitation (FDTL)

norms. On February 10, 2026, the 10 per cent cap on the airline's domestic schedule was removed as the relaxed FDTL norms were restored.

GREATER FLEXIBILITY These relaxed norms had earlier allowed greater flex-

ibility in crew deployment, including extended duty periods and reduced restrictions on night operations.

As per sources, DGCA teams will visit the airline's offices to review the functioning of its rostering software, along with pilots' key performance indicators (KPIs) and the overall availability of cockpit crew.

Till now, sources said that the regulator has been closely monitoring the airline's preparedness and operational planning, including measures to maintain adequate buffer strength in crew availability and to expedite pilot hiring to support operations.

IndiGo had earlier conveyed to the regulator that it plans to recruit about 50 pilots a month in 2026 as part of these efforts, sources said.

Currently, it has about 5,400 pilots on its rolls, including captains and first officers, according to industry estimates.

CREW SCHEDULES

Furthermore, the airline has recently updated its rostering software to better manage crew schedules and has made adjustments to pilots' KPIs, aligning operational targets with regulatory requirements and network reliability goals. However, regulatory oversight of the airline's transition and capacity planning will be maintained, sources said.

Additionally, routine engagements between the regulator and the airline, including periodic reviews of hiring plans and operational metrics, are continuing as part of this monitoring process.

'India's sovereign AI ecosystem crosses \$5.5 billion funding'



POLICY PUSH. The report noted that policy initiatives such as the ₹10,372 crore IndiaAI Mission have marked a structural shift

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

India's sovereign AI ecosystem has raised about \$5.5 billion in equity funding across more than 1,700 AI-native companies, according to a report by market intelligence platform, Tracxn. The ecosystem spans enterprise AI, vertical applications, consumer platforms and infrastructure layers.

The AI funding in India peaked at \$1.1 billion in 2022, slowed over the next two years, and rebounded to \$856 million in 2025. Funding has reached \$626 million so far in 2026.

The report noted that policy initiatives such as the ₹10,372 crore IndiaAI Mission have marked a structural shift. Earlier growth was led by applications built on global models and foreign infrastructure. It said newer measures signal deeper participation across upstream layers of the AI stack.

SPECIALISED MODELS

Under the IndiaAI Mission, 12 companies building foundational and specialised models have received structured GPU allocation. Public disclosures indicate domestic model development spanning 2.9 billion to 105

billion parameters.

The report highlighted infrastructure-focused funding rounds, including Neysa AI's \$600 million raise at an enterprise valuation of about \$1.4 billion. It said this reflects institutional interest in AI cloud and GPU-backed infrastructure.

Globally, cumulative AI funding has crossed about \$473 billion. A significant share is concentrated among frontier model developers such as OpenAI, Anthropic and xAI, which together account for an estimated \$170 billion.

The report said India's capital base remains smaller in absolute terms but is distributed across firms. It added that India's deployment strength is supported by population-scale digital platforms such as Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker, ONDC and Bhashini.

The report said that domestic training cycles were underway, compute allocation was expanding, infrastructure capital was scaling and digital public rails provided a structured base for deployment. It noted that the transition remains evolutionary, with foundational model ecosystems still in the build phase.

With inputs from intern Tejaswini S

Swiggy pulls plug on Snacc, focuses on core business as losses mount

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Food and grocery delivery major Swiggy has shut down Snacc, its standalone 15-minute food delivery app, just a year after piloting the service, signalling a sharper capital allocation strategy amid mounting losses and intensifying competition.

Launched as an experiment, Snacc was operational in Bengaluru and Gurugram but did not scale meaningfully over the past 12 months, according to people aware of the development. The move comes as the quick food delivery space sees rising action from incumbents and new entrants alike.

Rival Blinkit introduced Bistro as a separate app, while Zepto rolled out Zepto Cafe under a dedicated interface. Smaller players such as



LIMITED IMPACT. Snacc was operational in Bengaluru and Gurugram but did not scale meaningfully over the past 12 months

Accel-backed Swish have also attracted early investor and consumer traction in the rapid-meal segment. Meanwhile, mobility platform Rapido is charting plans to enter food delivery, further crowding the market.

Swiggy did not respond to queries. However, a person close to the matter said the company will absorb impacted employees across

other verticals. "We are absorbing people under our different businesses and providing them with transition support," the source said.

FINANCIAL PRESSURE

The closure comes against the backdrop of continued financial pressure. Swiggy recently closed a ₹10,000-crore qualified institutional

placement (QIP) on December 12, raising capital from institutional investors to strengthen its balance sheet and fund the expansion of Instamart, alongside investments in logistics and technology infrastructure.

In Q3FY26, Swiggy reported a consolidated net loss of ₹1,065 crore, widening from ₹799 crore in the year-ago period. Revenue from operations rose 54 per cent year-on-year to ₹6,148 crore, compared with ₹3,993 crore in the corresponding quarter last year. The decision to shutter Snacc suggests a recalibration of Swiggy's quick food ambitions, even as peers continue to double down on rapid delivery formats. With capital becoming more selective and competition intensifying, the battle for high-frequency food consumption is entering a more disciplined phase.



TRAINING TO BEGIN. Candidates will now start receiving phased updates, with virtual pre-skill training scheduled for approximately four to five weeks

technical hiring programme designed to identify and recruit top engineering talent from 46 premier institutes, including IIITs, NITs, and select top private colleges in India.

"This is the first time the company has provided a structured timeline after months of uncertainty, during which selected candidates who had received Letters of Intent and cleared

formalities were kept waiting without clarity," Harpreet Singh Saluja, President of NITES, said.

He added that Wipro acknowledged during the session that earlier, there was no business requirement. However, candidates will start receiving phased updates, with virtual pre-skill training scheduled for approximately four to five weeks.

MINISTRY VIEW

After NITES escalated the matter, the government formally took cognisance and referred the issue to the Karnataka Labour Department. Wipro did not respond to *businessline's* email seeking comments by the time of going to press.

SpiceJet plans to induct 10 aircraft, eyes major network expansion

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Budget airline SpiceJet plans to induct 10 more aircraft to rebuild its network as well as expand capacity.

Accordingly, the airline on Thursday said that it has received a memorandum of understanding (MoU) for induction purposes.

Further details on the MoU are awaited. *Businessline* has reached out to the airline.

WET AND DAMP LEASES

The development follows the Board's approval, announced last week, for a calibrated ramp-up of the fleet to 60 aircraft through a mix of wet and damp leases.



FLEET BOOST. The carrier has doubled its capacity in the last quarter, with available seat kilometres rising from around 55 crore to 105 crore

Besides, the plan includes the phased return to service of existing grounded aircraft.

According to the airline, its recovery has gathered pace in recent months.

Notably, the low-cost carrier has doubled its capacity in the last quarter, with available seat kilometres rising from around 55 crore to 105 crore.

Further, building on this

momentum, the airline plans to more than double its capacity during the year, targeting 220 crore available seat kilometres by winter 2026.

In addition, it aims to operate over 300 daily flights across its network.

As per the airline, the expansion is aimed at strengthening connectivity, improving operational reliability and meeting strong passen-

ger demand. Nevertheless, the airline stated that it will maintain a disciplined and sustainable approach to growth.

BIG MILESTONE

"Doubling our capacity in the last quarter has been a significant milestone, and the plans we have in place to more than double it further this year reflect growing confidence in the business and strong demand across the network," said Debojo Maharshi, Chief Business Officer at SpiceJet.

"The receipt of this memorandum of understanding is an encouraging development as we continue to rebuild and expand our operations in a measured manner."

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Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52WH	52WL	PE	BSE CI	
20 Microcons [1]	181.95	180.86	184.00	186.75	180.00	90.93	284.00	160.05	11	181.00	
30 One WAM [1]	1127.20	1150.00	1122.00	1127.00	1089.40	648.46	1273.80	795.50	-	-	
31 Airtel [1]	3691.00	3689.50	3681.00	3720.00	3638.00	355	3830.00	2571.35	27	3811.40	
34 SPAISA [1]	332.10	313.45	319.00	325.00	315.00	58.72	431.80	287.95	23	361.40	
63 MoonTea [2]	654.50	640.65	652.30	657.90	640.00	78.68	1130.00	575.05	70	641.45	
A											
Aadhar Hsg [1]	471.70	476.00	477.00	478.45	472.00	323.13	547.00	361.60	-	-	
Aadhar Drugs [1]	374.25	370.65	373.40	376.00	369.10	93.55	574.95	312.50	18	373.85	
Aarti Ind [1]	460.15	454.45	463.45	466.95	451.00	62.00	494.00	338.45	45	453.95	
Aarti Pharm [1]	721.19	713.30	722.90	726.65	710.00	88.98	971.00	574.45	-	-	
Aban [1]	1505.60	1289.00	1310.00	1311.00	1281.00	86.21	2386.35	126.00	16	1287.35	
AB Capital [1]	349.55	344.30	350.00	345.60	340.00	36.20	6020.38	369.25	150.00	30	344.15
AB InfraBuild [1]	21.19	20.76	21.28	21.51	20.57	4017.45	124.88	17.50	-	-	
AB Infra Ect [1]	15.40	15.30	15.40	15.45	15.25	61.00	11.00	15.40	-	-	
AB Sun Life [1]	896.05	896.15	897.05	910.88	888.00	115.42	918.00	556.45	-	-	
ABB [2]	5881.50	5719.50	5885.00	5908.00	5695.00	13.63	6299.00	459.05	69	5715.65	
ABB Powerpac [1]	2359.00	2285.10	2383.00	2399.00	2270.00	84.28	2371.00	1030.00	-	-	
Abnet [1]	2460.00	2460.00	2460.00	2460.00	2460.00	1.36	2921.50	2460.00	-	-	
ABFRL [1]	71.80	70.00	71.50	71.65	69.56	1596.87	70.17	59.82	-	-	
ACC [1]	1646.05	1617.60	1648.00	1646.80	1611.00	89.23	1123.30	1594.50	12	1619.15	
ACME Solar [1]	89.80	87.15	88.00	89.00	87.00	12.49	139.00	77.00	24	87.65	
Action Cons [1]	214.20	210.40	212.20	2105.00	2090.00	315.74	2553.50	104.00	-	-	
Acutaa Chem [1]	1000.00	998.00	1000.00	1000.00	998.00	1.12	1000.00	998.00	-	-	
Adani Green [1]	100.10	97.65	100.00	100.00	97.00	1500.05	175.20	75.80	218	97.65	
Adani Ports [2]	1550.15	1530.15	1550.00	1550.00	1530.15	1584.00	1036.35	126.15	152	1550.15	
Adani Pur [2]	144.19	140.45	145.10	146.40	140.00	1048.15	18.75	93.23	26	140.45	
Adani T Gas [1]	290.00	290.00	290.00	290.00	290.00	1.00	290.00	290.00	-	-	
Adani Wilam [1]	103.27	109.70	20.13	20.43	19.09	91.61	291.20	199.09	-	-	
Adani.E.Sol [1]	20.75	100.70	100.70	100.70	100.70	1.00	100.70	100.70	-	-	
AD Fash [1]	238.50	238.50	238.50	238.50	238.50	1.00	238.50	238.50	-	-	
Adityabirla [1]	109.14	106.77	110.15	110.45	106.12	66.60	175.10	106.86	-	-	
AdityaBirla [1]	1567.10	1565.00	1567.00	1594.00	1540.10	62.56	1745.10	1015.00	-	-	
AdityaVast [1]	490.00	491.10	489.00	493.00	486.00	27.27	580.00	327.60	-	-	
AdityaWells [1]	111.40	108.50	114.00	114.00	107.00	10.44	126.00	78.00	-	-	
Advant Ener [1]	170.20	166.60	171.50	174.80	165.80	14.12	188.00	135.10	-	-	
Advance Agro [1]	140.08	134.36	141.80	141.80	133.50	40.32	154.00	102.00	-	-	
Advanta [1]	238.50	238.50	238.50	238.50	238.50	1.00	238.50	238.50	-	-	
Advenzymes [2]	30.35	30.64	30.50	31.25	30.10	188.77	36.56	105.87	28	30.64	
Aegis Log [1]	69.20	68.10	69.35	69.88	67.00	105.34	96.46	63.90	57	68.13	
Aegis Vopak [1]	229.00	218.82	221.99	221.99	212.50	54.42	302.00	198.00	-	-	
AEGIS [1]	149.10	147.50	149.00	149.00	147.50	1.00	149.00	147.50	-	-	
Aeroflex Ind [1]	226.72	228.26	223.00	223.99	221.10	51.47	233.99	148.01	-	-	
AeroFlexEnt [1]	68.16	79.32	82.00	82.31	79.25	21.07	73.19	72.14	-	-	
Aero Ind [1]	129.00	129.00	129.00	129.00	129.00	1.00	129.00	129.00	-	-	
Afcons Infra [1]	32.30	32.00	32.30	32.50	31.90	17.07	48.00	31.00	-	-	
Affle [2]	1519.10	1502.00	1522.00	1535.00	1491.90	1.97	2186.12	1021.05	166	1502.00	
Afford Robo [1]	216.77	208.94	210.00	224.89	206.33	63.23	534.40	193.13	-	-	
Affinity [1]	61.50	61.50	61.50	61.50	61.50	1.00	61.50	61.50	-	-	
AGI Greenpac [1]	59.35	57.75	59.55	59.66	55.50	124.15	109.00	57.00	-	-	
AGI Infra [1]	261.80	263.95	265.00	273.00	259.30	282.57	440.00	224.70	-	-	
AGI Infra [1]	81.50	81.50	81.50	81.50	81.50	1.00	81.50	81.50	-	-	
AIA Eng [1]	40.21	39.60	40.00	40.30	39.40	10.00	28.30	42.00	360.00	29	39.60
Ajanta Pwr [2]	2961.90	2959.70	2976.00	2991.50	2950.17	76.31	3020.45	2022.05	39	2959.15	
Ajan Agri [1]	493.75	483.55	498.75	498.75	483.55	1.00	498.75	483.55	-	-	
Ajan Agri [1]	535.00	522.00	530.00	534.00	522.00	71.22	522.00	535.00	-	-	
Ajan Agri [1]	18.00	18.00	18.00	18.00	18.00	1.00	18.00	18.00	-	-	
AKme Fin [1]	5.54	5.43	5.56	5.69	5.37	1143.42	9.07	3.92	-	-	
Akums Drugs [1]	487.85	487.50	493.90	506.06	482.05	461.29	62.95	405.00	-	-	
Aktu Ind [1]	346.00	341.20	338.90	337.50	338.00	1.00	338.90	337.50	-	-	
ALAM PHAR [2]	77.50	76.57	77.30	78.40	76.50	32.60	110.70	72.50	60	76.57	
Alchemb Ltd [1]	95.59	95.32	96.00	96.00	93.00	204.74	127.80	85.55	17	95.32	
Alco Ind [1]	100.00	100.00	100.00	100.00	100.00	1.00	100.00	100.00	-	-	
AlivisLife [1]	89.00	89.00	89.00	89.00	89.00	1.00	89.00	89.00	-	-	
Alkem labs [2]	5464.50	5370.00	5517.00	5517.00	5350.00	190.96	5393.00	4498.90	29	5374.00	
ALKYL AMIN [2]	1531.10	1520.50	1531.20	1535.50	1515.70	17.87	2448.80	1506.60	43	1521.15	
Alkyl Amin [1]	166.00	161.50	166.00	166.00	161.50	1.00	166.00	161.50	-	-	
Alkyl Amin [1]	27.05	26.50	26.50	27.10	25.90	39.48	40.00	21.21	-	-	
Allegro Tech [1]	812.15	812.40	819.00	819.00	811.00	5.95	1084.00	779.00	-	-	
Allegro Tech [1]	521.20	506.05	521.95	522.50	507.66	22.77	66.00	29.00	-	-	
AlliedBlend [1]	25.84	24.71	25.48	26.00	24.40	39.08	33.40	21.80	-	-	
Allot Ind [1]	14.99	14.91	14.99	15.07	14.84	26.74	20.20	23.50	-	-	
Alloy Metals [1]	29.00	29.00	29.00	29.00	29.00	1.00	29.00	29.00	-	-	
Almaraj,Enr [1]	54.16	84.80	86.00	86.00	84.85	21.62	110.00	81.00	-	-	
Amber [1]	7894.00	7705.50	7877.00	7916.00	7673.00	157.63	8625.00	5382.90	186	7705.55	
Amber [1]	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00	1.00	15.00	15.00	-	-	
Anand Rathis [1]	3008.00	3022.70	3022.00	3043.00	3000.50	132.24	4250.00	1594.00	-	-	
AnandRathis [1]	57.35	52.65	54.35	54.30	50.00	157.47	79.85	43.10	-	-	
Anand R [1]	556.15	545.75	556.25	576.00	541.50	55.52	744.10	366.15	-	-	
Anand R [1]	48.35	48.35	48.35	48.35	48.35	1.00	48.35	48.35	-	-	
Andhra Paper [1]	69.88	69.14	69.99	71.89	67.02	166.94	90.00	61.16	-	-	
Andhra Sp [1]	73.88	72.27	73.49	74.49	72.10	66.49	97.99	63.27	-	-	
Andhra Sp [1]	2259.10	2259.10	2259.10	2259.10	2259.10	1.00	2259.10	2259.10	-	-	
Antion Health [1]	121.82	121.00	121.82	122.31	111.00	66.43	172.75	90.78	-	-	
Antion Health [1]	589.35	612.60	591.55	639.00	593.45	96.74	79.67	357.00	-	-	
AntionBioSci [1]	68.45	68.40	68.50	68.50	68.40	1.00	68.50	68.40	-	-	
AntionBioSci [1]	100.00	100.00	100.00	100.00	100.00	1.00	100.00	100.00	-	-	
Anuh Phr [1]	77.38	75.86	78.90	78.90	75.21	48.17	229.80	69.27	-	-	
Anup Engg [1]	179.30	172.80	180.00	182.20	171.00	65.16	363.85	170.00	-	-	
Anup Engg [1]	100.00	100.00	100.00	100.00	100.00	1.00	100.00	100.00	-	-	
Apac Ind [1]	10182.00	10030.00	10200.00	10400.00	9950.00	6.17	10416.50	479.00	-	-	
Apac Ind [1]	43.60	44.20	43.90	46.55	44.20	44.02	44.58	17.20	-	-	
APOLLO [2]	23.85	23.41	23.70	23.90	23.30	123.53	35.66	10.05	85	23.41	
Apollo Hosp. [1]	7647.50	7592.60	7610.00	7649.00	7551.50	186.71	8099.00	6002.15	75	7587.90	
Apollo Pipes [1]	332.75	333.05	332.00	335.20	328.05	27.46	49.95	252.10	-	-	
Apollo Pipes [1]	163.60	163.60	163.60	163.60	163.60	1.00	163.60	163.60	-	-	
Aptech Ltd [1]	95.45	90.01	96.25	96.40	90.10	152.33	182.40	75.00	26	96.25	
Apus V Hsg [1]	249.25	249.25	249.25	249.25	249.25	1.00	249.25	249.25	-	-	
Apus V Hsg [1]	566.60	566.60	566.60	566.60	566.60	1.00	566.60	566.60	-	-	
Aravind [1]	71.31	70.56	71.35	72.10	70.00	50.00	80.01	31.43	-	-	
ARIES AGRO [1]	362.45	364.30	365.55	365.55	341.65	66.71	49.09	215.60	12	364.80	
Arin Super [1]	26.95	26.05	26.35	26.55	26.00	40.00	46.15	25.90	-	-	
Arin Super [1]	78.47	78.47	78.47	78.47	78.47	1.00	78.47	78.47	-	-	
Arinifra So [1]	116.44	114.61	116.00	116.49	113.11	70.83	20.80	82.18	-	-	
Arkade Dev [1]	21.35	118.88	122.96	122.96	111.17	220.68	213.59	107.56	-	-	
Arka Ind [1]	163.60	163.60	163.60	163.60	163.60	1.00	163.60	163.60	-	-	
Artemis Med [1]	238.90	238.90	238.90	238.90	238.90	1.00	238.90	238.90	-	-	
Arvind Fash [1]	471.45	468.40	479.00	480.85	465.00	53.30	570.95	338.00	-	-	
Arvind Ltd [1]	377.20	365.25	374.00	379.00	363.30	299.95	35.95	271.55	-	-	
Arvind Ltd [1]	54.00	54.00	54.00	54.00</							

